

Resource: Study Notes (Tyndale)

Aquifer Open Study Notes

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NUM

Numbers 1:1, Numbers 1:1–16, Numbers 1:1–10.10, Numbers 1:2–16, Numbers 1:16, Numbers 1:17–46, Numbers 1:20–43, Numbers 1:47–54, Numbers 1:50, Numbers 1:50–53, Numbers 2:1–34, Numbers 2:2, Numbers 2:3–9, Numbers 2:10–16, Numbers 2:18–24, Numbers 2:25–31, Numbers 2:34, Numbers 3:1–4, Numbers 3:1–4.49, Numbers 3:4, Numbers 3:5–13, Numbers 3:10, Numbers 3:11–13, Numbers 3:14–39, Numbers 3:27–32, Numbers 3:28, Numbers 3:32, Numbers 3:38, Numbers 3:39, Numbers 3:40–51, Numbers 4:1, Numbers 4:1–49, Numbers 4:3, Numbers 4:4–20, Numbers 4:15, Numbers 4:21–28, Numbers 4:29–33, Numbers 4:34–49, Numbers 5:1–4, Numbers 5:1–31, Numbers 5:1–10.10, Numbers 5:2, Numbers 5:5–10, Numbers 5:6, Numbers 5:7, Numbers 5:8, Numbers 5:9–10, Numbers 5:11–31, Numbers 5:14–15, Numbers 5:17, Numbers 5:21, Numbers 5:23–24, Numbers 5:29–31, Numbers 6:1–21, Numbers 6:2, Numbers 6:3–4, Numbers 6:5, Numbers 6:6–8, Numbers 6:9–21, Numbers 6:22–27, Numbers 6:24, Numbers 6:24–26, Numbers 6:25, Numbers 6:26, Numbers 6:27, Numbers 7:1, Numbers 7:1–89, Numbers 7:2–9, Numbers 7:9, Numbers 7:10–11, Numbers 7:12–83, Numbers 7:84–88, Numbers 7:89, Numbers 8:1–4, Numbers 8:5–22, Numbers 8:7, Numbers 8:10–11, Numbers 8:11, Numbers 8:12–22, Numbers 8:19, Numbers 8:23–26, Numbers 9:1–14, Numbers 9:2–3, Numbers 9:4–7, Numbers 9:8, Numbers 9:9–14, Numbers 9:12, Numbers 9:13, Numbers 9:14, Numbers 9:15–23, Numbers 9:19–23, Numbers 10:1–10, Numbers 10:2–4, Numbers 10:5–8, Numbers 10:8, Numbers 10:9–10, Numbers 10:11–36, Numbers 10:12, Numbers 10:13–28, Numbers 10:29–32, Numbers 10:33, Numbers 10:35, Numbers 10:36, Numbers 11:1, Numbers 11:1–35, Numbers 11:2–3, Numbers 11:4–6, Numbers 11:4–15, Numbers 11:6, Numbers 11:7–9, Numbers 11:10–15, Numbers 11:16–30, Numbers 11:25, Numbers 11:28–29, Numbers 11:31–35, Numbers 11:34–35, Numbers 12:1, Numbers 12:1–2, Numbers 12:1–16, Numbers 12:2, Numbers 12:3, Numbers 12:4–8, Numbers 12:6–8, Numbers 12:9–16, Numbers 12:14, Numbers 12:16, Numbers 13:1–16, Numbers 13:1–14.45, Numbers 13:17–20, Numbers 13:20, Numbers 13:21, Numbers 13:21–24, Numbers 13:22, Numbers 13:25–29, Numbers 13:26, Numbers 13:27, Numbers 13:29, Numbers 13:30, Numbers 13:33, Numbers 14:1–45, Numbers 14:3–4, Numbers 14:5, Numbers 14:6, Numbers 14:7–9, Numbers 14:10, Numbers 14:11, Numbers 14:12, Numbers 14:13–25, Numbers 14:17–18, Numbers 14:19, Numbers 14:20–25, Numbers 14:22, Numbers 14:23–25, Numbers 14:28, Numbers 14:34, Numbers 14:39–45, Numbers 14:43, Numbers 14:44, Numbers 14:45, Numbers 15:1–3, Numbers 15:1–41, Numbers 15:3, Numbers 15:12–16, Numbers 15:17–21, Numbers 15:22–29, Numbers 15:30–31, Numbers 15:32–36, Numbers 15:34, Numbers 15:37–41, Numbers 16:1–17.13, Numbers 16:3, Numbers 16:4–7, Numbers 16:6, Numbers 16:10, Numbers 16:13, Numbers 16:14, Numbers 16:15, Numbers 16:16–17, Numbers 16:18–22, Numbers 16:19, Numbers 16:21–26, Numbers 16:26, Numbers 16:28–30, Numbers 16:31–33, Numbers 16:34–35, Numbers 16:37, Numbers 16:38–40, Numbers 16:41, Numbers 16:42–48, Numbers 16:46–50, Numbers 17:1–5, Numbers 17:1–13, Numbers 17:4, Numbers 17:8, Numbers 17:9–11, Numbers 17:12–13, Numbers 18:1–4, Numbers 18:1–32, Numbers 18:3–4, Numbers 18:5, Numbers 18:5–7, Numbers 18:6–7, Numbers 18:7, Numbers 18:8–14, Numbers 18:9–11, Numbers 18:14, Numbers 18:15–16, Numbers 18:19, Numbers 18:20–21, Numbers 18:23–24, Numbers 18:25–32, Numbers 18:31, Numbers 18:32, Numbers 19:1–10, Numbers 19:1–22, Numbers 19:3–5, Numbers 19:6, Numbers 19:7–10, Numbers 19:9, Numbers 19:11–19, Numbers 19:13, Numbers 19:14–16, Numbers 19:17–22, Numbers 20:1, Numbers 20:2, Numbers 20:2–13, Numbers 20:3, Numbers 20:6, Numbers 20:7–9, Numbers 20:8–9, Numbers 20:10–12, Numbers 20:13, Numbers 20:14–21, Numbers 20:14–21.35, Numbers 20:17, Numbers 20:18–21, Numbers 20:22–23, Numbers 20:24–26, Numbers 20:27–29, Numbers 21:1, Numbers 21:1–22.1, Numbers 21:2–3, Numbers 21:4–9, Numbers 21:6, Numbers 21:7–9, Numbers 21:10, Numbers 21:11–12, Numbers 21:13, Numbers 21:14–15, Numbers 21:16–18, Numbers 21:18–20, Numbers 21:21–22, Numbers 21:21–24, Numbers 21:21–35, Numbers 21:25, Numbers 21:26, Numbers 21:27–30, Numbers 21:28, Numbers 21:29, Numbers 21:30, Numbers 21:33–35, Numbers 21:35, Numbers 22:1, Numbers 22:2–3, Numbers 22:2–24.25, Numbers 22:4, Numbers 22:5–6, Numbers 22:7, Numbers 22:8, Numbers 22:9–18, Numbers 22:18, Numbers 22:19–20, Numbers 22:21–41, Numbers 22:22, Numbers 22:28–31, Numbers 22:34, Numbers 22:35, Numbers 22:36, Numbers 22:37, Numbers 22:38, Numbers 22:39–41, Numbers 22:41, Numbers 23:1, Numbers 23:1–30, Numbers 23:7–8, Numbers 23:7–10, Numbers 23:13–26, Numbers 23:18–24, Numbers 23:19, Numbers 23:20–21, Numbers 23:23–24, Numbers 23:27–24.14, Numbers 24:1–2, Numbers 24:3–9, Numbers 24:5–6, Numbers 24:6–7, Numbers 24:7–9, Numbers 24:10, Numbers 24:14, Numbers 24:15–25, Numbers 24:17, Numbers 24:21–22, Numbers 24:23,

Numbers 24:23–24, Numbers 24:24, Numbers 24:25, Numbers 25:1, Numbers 25:1–18, Numbers 25:2, Numbers 25:3, Numbers 25:4, Numbers 25:6, Numbers 25:7–9, Numbers 25:10–13, Numbers 25:13, Numbers 25:16–18, Numbers 26:1–4, Numbers 26:1–65, Numbers 26:8–11, Numbers 26:33, Numbers 26:51, Numbers 26:52–56, Numbers 26:57–61, Numbers 26:62, Numbers 26:63–65, Numbers 27:1–11, Numbers 27:2, Numbers 27:3–4, Numbers 27:5–11, Numbers 27:12, Numbers 27:12–23, Numbers 27:15–17, Numbers 27:18–19, Numbers 27:20–21, Numbers 28:1–2, Numbers 28:1–29.40, Numbers 28:2, Numbers 28:3–8, Numbers 28:9–10, Numbers 28:11–15, Numbers 28:16–25, Numbers 28:26–31, Numbers 29:1–6, Numbers 29:7, Numbers 29:7–11, Numbers 29:12–38, Numbers 29:39, Numbers 30:1–2, Numbers 30:1–16, Numbers 30:3–5, Numbers 30:6–8, Numbers 30:9, Numbers 30:10–15, Numbers 31:1–2, Numbers 31:3–5, Numbers 31:6, Numbers 31:7, Numbers 31:8, Numbers 31:9–13, Numbers 31:10, Numbers 31:13, Numbers 31:14–16, Numbers 31:17–18, Numbers 31:19–24, Numbers 31:25–31, Numbers 31:32–35, Numbers 31:36–47, Numbers 31:48–49, Numbers 31:50–54, Numbers 32:1, Numbers 32:1–5, Numbers 32:3, Numbers 32:6–15, Numbers 32:12, Numbers 32:16–19, Numbers 32:20–24, Numbers 32:25–27, Numbers 32:28–30, Numbers 32:31–32, Numbers 32:33–42, Numbers 32:34–36, Numbers 32:37–38, Numbers 32:39–42, Numbers 33:1–2, Numbers 33:1–56, Numbers 33:3, Numbers 33:4, Numbers 33:5–15, Numbers 33:6, Numbers 33:9, Numbers 33:14, Numbers 33:15, Numbers 33:16–17, Numbers 33:16–36, Numbers 33:18–30, Numbers 33:30–31, Numbers 33:35, Numbers 33:36, Numbers 33:37–49, Numbers 33:38–39, Numbers 33:42–49, Numbers 33:47, Numbers 33:50–56, Numbers 33:54, Numbers 33:55–56, Numbers 34:1–29, Numbers 34:3–5, Numbers 34:4, Numbers 34:5, Numbers 34:6–9, Numbers 34:11, Numbers 34:12, Numbers 34:13–15, Numbers 34:16–29, Numbers 34:19–28, Numbers 35:1–34, Numbers 35:4–5, Numbers 35:6–34, Numbers 35:12, Numbers 35:15, Numbers 35:15–24, Numbers 35:19, Numbers 35:22–23, Numbers 35:24–25, Numbers 35:26–29, Numbers 35:30, Numbers 35:31–32, Numbers 35:33, Numbers 35:34, Numbers 36:1–4, Numbers 36:1–13, Numbers 36:5, Numbers 36:6–9, Numbers 36:10–12, Numbers 36:13

participate in the conquest. The nation was transitioning from slavery to nationhood.

Numbers 1:1

In the year after Israel's departure from Egypt, the Lord frequently communicated his will to the people through Moses and gave them every opportunity to conform to his divine plan. • God's self-disclosure often took place at the Tabernacle (literally *the Tent of Meeting*; see study note on Exod 27:21). • The wilderness of Sinai was a great, terrifying, and inhospitable desert ([Deut 1:19](#)). This relatively unpopulated region was the anvil on which God forged Israel as the environmental challenges of Sinai tested Israel's dependence upon the Lord throughout the book of Numbers. Sinai reminded later biblical authors of the law and of Israel's rebellious spirit ([Ps 106:19](#); [Heb 12:25–26](#)).

Numbers 1:1–16

One family leader from each tribe (except Levi) was appointed to count Israel's men of fighting age.

Numbers 1:1–10.10

The Israelites prepared to leave for the Promised Land by registering all the troops eligible to

Numbers 1:2–16

- *those who are twenty years of age or older by their divisions—everyone who can serve in Israel's army:* This registration gathered more information than the earlier census (compare [Exodus 38:26](#)).
- *These are the names of the men who are to assist you:* Hebrew culture was tribal, centered around clans and families. They easily identified the tribal leaders, who appear again as a group in [Numbers 7](#).
- Moses and Aaron did not include the tribe of Levi in this registration because it had a special status in Israelite society (see [Numbers 1:47–53](#); [26:51–62](#); [Deuteronomy 18:5](#); [33:8–11](#)).

Numbers 1:16

These tribal leaders had apparently shown themselves responsible and trustworthy by fulfilling other important duties.

Numbers 1:17-46

The tabulation yields the same number of qualified men (603,550) as mentioned in [Exod 38:26](#), [Exodus 12:37](#) and [Num 11:21](#) give an approximate number of 600,000. These numbers have been interpreted in different ways. They might reflect the literal size of this army (cp. [Exod 1:9-10](#)); alternatively, the figures might be symbolic, projected backward from a later period, or simply misunderstood in translation. See also study note on Exod 12:37.

Numbers 1:20-43

In this second list of the tribes, Gad is placed alongside Reuben and Simeon, the tribes with whom Gad would camp while Israel was on the march.

Numbers 1:47-54

The tribe of Levi did not serve in Israel's army with the other tribes. This section of Numbers describes the organization of Levites for service in the Tabernacle, which was their primary responsibility.

Numbers 1:50

tabernacle of the Testimony: This was a portable sanctuary. It symbolized the Lord's presence and showed Israel's covenant relationship with him.

Numbers 1:50-53

The Levites had the job of setting up, taking down, moving, and guarding the tabernacle. They kept unauthorized people from coming too close or making it unclean. This protected the Israelites from the Lord's judgment.

Numbers 2:1-34

Israel's camps were to be organized by tribal groupings. This arrangement may have reflected concerns for social status, access to water, and security for the Tabernacle, which represented the Lord's presence. The Egyptian army from approximately this same era camped in a similar defensive formation to protect the sacred objects that accompanied their field campaigns.

Numbers 2:2

Each area of the Hebrew camp was identified by family banners, which were probably flags or streamers ([1:52](#)). The use of such tribal symbols or battle flags finds an analogy in modern bedouin life, where the divisions of tribe, clan, and family have long held great importance. • The tribes camped around the sanctuary at a safe distance (cp. [Josh 3:4](#)) that respected the gap between God's holiness and the non-Levitical tribes.

Numbers 2:3-9

The tribes of Judah, Issachar, and Zebulun camped in the most prestigious place on the east side of the Tabernacle and led the way when Israel was on the move. This largest of the tribal groups (186,400) could provide adequate protection for the sacred tent and its attendants.

Numbers 2:10-16

The tribes of Reuben, Simeon, and Gad camped on the south. With their 151,450 warriors, they took second place in the line of march.

Numbers 2:18-24

The tribes of Ephraim, Manasseh, and Benjamin marched behind the Tabernacle and the Levites.

Numbers 2:25-31

The tribes of Dan, Asher, and Naphtali brought up the rear.

Numbers 2:34

The Hebrews initially obeyed God by camping and marching in the manner Moses had specified, but this obedient spirit did not last for long.

Numbers 3:1-4

The family line of Aaron provided the professional priests who led Israel's worship. Aaron's four sons were the foundation of Israel's priesthood; they stood in God's presence and served him on behalf of the people. They were appointed to lead the people and serve the Lord as ministers in the Tabernacle and as guardians of God's covenant with his people.

Numbers 3:1-4:49

The duties of Israel's priests and Levites included the transportation, assembly, safety, and upkeep of the Tabernacle. The physical arrangement of Israel's tribes reflected concern for these activities.

Numbers 3:4

- The deaths of *Nadab and Abihu* (see [Leviticus 10:1-2](#)) showed the need to protect the holiness of the sanctuary and to strictly obey God's instructions ([Numbers 26:61](#); [Leviticus 16:1](#); [1 Chronicles 24:2](#); compare [Acts 5:1-11](#); [1 Corinthians 10:6-11](#); [11:29-30](#)).
- *Eleazar and Ithamar*: See "Eleazar" Profile.

Numbers 3:5-13

The Levites were appointed as assistants to the priests, who were represented by Aaron. Their ministry included sacred duties ([3:7](#)) in maintaining the Tabernacle and its furnishings ([3:8](#); described in greater detail in [4:1-33](#)).

Numbers 3:10

The sanctuary was set apart for God's holy use ([Numbers 1:51](#); [3:38](#); [18:7](#)). Only qualified people could approach it (compare [3:4](#)).

Numbers 3:11-13

The firstborn sons . . . of Israel belonged to God, having been spared when the Egyptian firstborn sons died ([3:13](#); see [Exod 11-12](#)). The Levites were chosen . . . to serve as substitutes in their place.

Numbers 3:14-39

This first phase of a two-stage registration of the tribe of Levi (see [4:34-49](#) for stage two) summarized each family group's special responsibilities (described in greater detail in [4:1-33](#)). This numbering was not linked with military duties, so it enrolled male Levites from the age of one month ([3:40-41](#)). • Three family groups are descended from Gershon, Kohath, and Merari, the three sons of Levi. These clans (often called the Gershonites, Kohathites, and Merarites) later inherited the "cities of refuge" ([Josh 21](#)) and filled various important posts in the Jerusalem Temple ([2 Chr 29:3-17](#)).

Numbers 3:27-32

Aaron and Moses, sons of Amram, were descendants of Kohath (see [Exod 6:18, 20, 26](#)). Because they were caretakers of the sanctuary (the Most Holy Place) and its very sacred furnishings (described in [Num 3-4](#)), the Kohathites were the most highly regarded of the three clans.

Numbers 3:28

8,600: Some Greek manuscripts read *8,300*. The "six" (Hebrew *shsh*) in 8,600 could result from misreading a "three" (Hebrew *shlsh*).

Numbers 3:32

Eleazar, Aaron's third son, presided over the Levites as administrator (perhaps as an executive secretary), while his father dealt with other

matters; he had special . . . oversight of the Tabernacle ([4:16–20](#)). He played an important role in Israel's wilderness period and later succeeded his father as high priest (see [16:37–39](#); [19:3–6](#); [20:25–28](#); [26:1–3](#)).

Numbers 3:38

The preeminent campsite east of the Tabernacle was reserved for . . . Moses, Aaron, and his priestly sons.

Numbers 3:39

22,000: The numbers listed for each clan ([3:22](#), [28](#), [34](#)) add up to 22,300. See study note on 3:28.

Numbers 3:40–51

There were 273 more firstborn sons in Israel from the non-Levite tribes than there were Levite males (compare [Leviticus 3:39](#)). The Levites acted as substitutes for Israel's firstborn sons ([3:41](#); see study note on 3:11–13). The law required a redemption price of five pieces of silver for each extra firstborn son ([Numbers 3:46–48](#); compare [Leviticus 27:6](#)).

It is unclear who paid this cost. This arrangement for special substitutes points to Christ's role as a substitute. Through his death, Christ paid the redemption price for all humanity (see [Mark 10:45](#); [Galatians 3:13](#); [Ephesians 1:7](#); [Hebrews 9:15](#)).

Numbers 4:1

Moses and Aaron were mediators of God's will regarding the care and transport of the Tabernacle, the primary charge of the three Levitical families.

Numbers 4:1–49

This section expands the discussion begun in [3:21–37](#) on the duties of the three clans of Levites. The Levites—on the march and encamped—carried and cared for the Tabernacle and were always surrounded by the other tribes so that they and their precious cargo would be safe ([2:17](#)). The sacred things associated with God were placed in

the middle of the tribes, and the role of the priests and their Levitical assistants was to keep them holy by keeping them separate. • God, in his holiness, is worthy of attention to the details of his will. His Tabernacle and its furnishings were sacred, and the tribe of Levi was responsible to maintain the distinction between holy and common, between clean and unclean. This explains why so much information is provided about the duties of the three clans of Levites.

Numbers 4:3

Of the 22,000 Levites ([3:39](#)), only men between the ages of thirty and fifty, those in the prime of their life, were allowed to serve in the sanctuary. The summary of this registration (another “numbering”) found in [4:34–49](#) gives the total number of qualified males as 8,580.

Numbers 4:4–20

The duties of the Kohathites (see [3:27–32](#)) are listed first because they performed a special service related to the most sacred objects (perhaps because Aaron and the priests came from this clan; [1 Chr 6:2–3](#)). The tasks of carrying, setting up, and disassembling these sacred coverings and furnishings were extremely important. All the things entrusted to Kohath's descendants—the Ark of the Covenant, the table of the Bread of the Presence, the lampstand (Hebrew menorah), the gold incense altar, and the altar for sacrifices—held tremendous value. These objects are first described in [Exod 25–30](#), but Numbers shows how they were integrated into Hebrew life. The Kohathites carried these items on poles or in frames, and they were not to touch them or enter the sanctuary to look at them on penalty of death.

Numbers 4:15

Aaron and his surviving sons Eleazar and Ithamar had to cover the sanctuary and all the sacred articles completely before the camp was ready to move, with the groups of non-Levitical tribes marching before and behind the Levites who carried the Tabernacle. The royalty of these objects is seen in the symbolic colors of the coverings, and their sacredness underlies the stern warning that even though the Kohathites were the designated

handlers, they must not touch the sacred objects, or they would die. Such respect marked the holiness of Israel's Lord. The dangers of disregarding these instructions are apparent in [1 Sam 6:19–20](#) and [2 Sam 6:6–7](#).

Numbers 4:21–28

The men of the Gershonite clan (see [3:21–26](#)) were responsible for general service and carrying loads ([4:24](#)). This involved handling the curtains and coverings, ropes, and related equipment that was less central to Israel's worship. Their duties focused on the Tabernacle in general instead of on the sacred objects of the inner sanctuary that were the responsibility of Kohath's clan.

Numbers 4:29–33

Even this assignment to the Merarite clan, which focused on items of lesser priority than those handled by the Kohathites and Gershonites, had to be done in a specific way, and the various loads were assigned to each man by name ([4:32](#); cp. [1 Cor 14:40](#)). While the Gershonites and Merarites lacked the status of Kohath's family, each group contributed to the process of moving and erecting the Tabernacle.

Numbers 4:34–49

The process of numbering and recording the Levites' names and making sure that each man understood his assignment was an important step in organizing Israel to travel and camp in the correct manner and in safeguarding the Tabernacle.

Numbers 5:1–4

- Modern Western people may find it difficult to understand the Old Testament laws of purity. Today, things like skin diseases, bodily discharges, or contact with a dead body are viewed mainly as health concerns. But in the Old Testament, the main concern was protecting God's holiness from ceremonial uncleanness (see [Leviticus 11–15](#)).

The community had to keep the camp holy. Nothing unclean could touch what belonged to the Lord ([Numbers 5:2–3](#)). They had to choose between having God in the camp or allowing a ceremonially polluted person stay. Both could not remain ([5:3](#)).

- The importance of purity continues from Leviticus and Numbers to the book of Revelation. Nothing ceremonially unclean will enter the New Jerusalem where God lives (see study note on Revelation 21:27). In the New Testament, impurity most often refers to what is morally impure ([Acts 10:28](#); [Ephesians 5:5](#); [1 Thessalonians 2:3](#); [4:7](#)).

Numbers 5:1–31

These laws concern purity, restitution, and marital faithfulness.

Numbers 5:1–10.10

These legal matters were to ensure the purity of the Israelites, their priesthood, and the Tabernacle. Such regulations drew constant attention to ancient Israel's identity as a theocracy of which Moses was the primary spokesman.

Numbers 5:2

skin disease: The Hebrew word used here describes various skin diseases that were regarded as contagious (cp. [Lev 13–14](#)). • Discharge refers to fluids associated with sexual organs ([Lev 15](#); cp.

[Luke 8:43–48](#)). • touching a dead person: See [Num 6:6–11](#); [19:11](#).

Numbers 5:5–10

Guidelines regarding confession and restitution for wrongdoing emphasize the strong Hebrew concern for morality ([Lev 6:1–7](#)).

Numbers 5:6

Harming another person is also betraying the Lord (literally *to act unfaithful in unfaithfulness*; compare [Leviticus 5:8](#)). Being right with God leads to being right with others. If we treat others wrongly, it shows our relationship with the Lord is not right.

Numbers 5:7

This restitution and the guilt offering (see [Lev 6–7](#)) associated with the sin was intended to inculcate a heightened sense of individual responsibility to God's holiness.

Numbers 5:8

- Since sin is ultimately against God, the one doing wrong must make restitution to the *LORD* ([Leviticus 5:6](#); [Psalm 51:4](#)). God allowed the human victims of the sin to receive this payment. If no victims were alive, the priest would receive the payment on behalf of the LORD. Those doing wrong must also offer a valuable sacrifice to restore their ceremonial purity and their relationship with God ([Numbers 5:1–4](#)).
- *the atonement is made for him*: See study note on [Leviticus 1:4](#).

Numbers 5:9–10

Priests supported their families partly by receiving a share of the sacrifices. In some instances, surplus

sacrifices could be sold to provide funds for the priesthood, for maintaining the sanctuary, and for other religious needs (cp. [1 Cor 8:4–13](#)).

Numbers 5:11–31

This detailed test for adultery, a “trial by ordeal,” is the only such case found in the Old Testament, though trial by ordeal was a common procedure in the ancient Near East. God had a special interest in safeguarding marriage as the foundation of Hebrew society, and the purpose of this ordeal was to promote marital faithfulness. We cannot determine how commonly such ordeals actually occurred. This procedure appealed to God's own intervention to ensure justice in cases lacking evidence (cp. [1 Cor 5:5](#)).

Numbers 5:14–15

The husband presented his case before the priest, and the “ritual law for dealing with suspicion” ([5:29](#)) took the husband's jealousy and suspicion to a higher court.

Numbers 5:17

The holy water and the dust were sacred because of their association with the sanctuary.

Numbers 5:21

when he makes you infertile, causing your womb to shrivel: Literally *when he causes your thigh to waste away*. “Thigh” is a euphemism for the reproductive organs (cp. [Gen 24:2](#); [47:29](#)); something would go wrong with her reproductive abilities. The punishment suited the crime as sexual immorality resulted in the inability to have children.

Numbers 5:23–24

The symbolism of drinking disturbing words is repeated in [Ezek 2:8–3:3](#) and [Rev 10:8–11](#).

Numbers 5:29–31

As the trial by ordeal is summarized and justified, it is clear that a husband's questions about his wife's guilt or innocence did not burden him with any guilt. We might raise the question of a double standard, but it was very common for ancient laws to draw attention to the woman's failure in the matter of adultery. However, Israel's legal system provided for the punishment of both parties to an affair (as in [Lev 20:10](#); [Deut 22:21–22](#)).

Numbers 6:1–21

The voluntary Nazirite vow allowed men or women to set themselves apart for the Lord. There was considerable variation in how the Nazirite lifestyle was practiced in various periods of Hebrew history. Vows were taken very seriously in ancient times as a well-established means of expressing devotion or gratitude to God. This vow could be temporary or permanent; it involved refraining from alcoholic drinks, hair cutting, and contact with corpses. Nazirite restrictions gave members of non-Levitical tribes a way to enter into a more demanding and highly respected relationship with God. The Nazirite vow is probably best known because of Samson ([Judg 13–16](#)). See also [1 Sam 1:11](#); [Jer 35](#); [Acts 18:8](#); [21:23–26](#); cp. [Luke 1:15](#).

Numbers 6:2

Nazirite: The Hebrew term *nazir* is derived from a verb that means “to separate.”

Numbers 6:3–4

The law required priests to avoid drinking wine before they served in the Tabernacle ([Lev 10:9](#)); the Nazirite vow allowed non-Levites to broaden that law to include all places, all times, and anything that comes from a grapevine.

Numbers 6:5

Hair had special symbolic significance (cp. [Lev 19:27](#)); religious persons often left their hair uncut or shaved it off entirely ([Num 8:5–7](#)). The Israelites were not expected to leave their hair entirely uncut, but the Nazirites were.

Numbers 6:6–8

Dead bodies defiled whoever touched them ([9:6–10](#)). Priests were only allowed to touch the dead bodies of close relatives ([Lev 21:1–4](#)), but even that was forbidden to Nazirites.

Numbers 6:9–21

Provisions were made for restoring purity in cases of unavoidable contact with a corpse. Special procedures and offerings brought the period of the Nazirite vow to a conclusion. A stern warning is added about actually fulfilling the vow ([6:21](#)).

Numbers 6:22–27

The priestly benediction is related to the overall theme of worship and purity in chs [5–6](#). This is a prayer on behalf of the people as the priests sought God's blessings for Israel. Since the priest represented God, such prayer was part of the priestly duty (cp. [Lev 9:23](#); [Deut 10:8](#)). This prayer is not unlike Jesus' high priestly prayer in [John 17](#).

Numbers 6:24

The blessings sought in the first half of this verse include health, wealth, and fertility, while the protection mentioned in the second half was needed for all manner of dangers. This supplication is echoed in the language of [Pss 121:3–8](#); [140:4](#); and [141:9](#). These heartfelt appeals are still good models for prayer and for the blessings that God's people can seek for all humanity. The entire poem draws attention to the Lord as the source of all good things.

Numbers 6:24–26

[Psalm 67:1](#) contains an abbreviated version of this benediction, much like one inscribed on a silver amulet excavated at Ketef Hinnom, southwest of Jerusalem's Old City. On a second, larger silver amulet from the same tomb, the complete benediction was inscribed in words almost identical to those here. In the days of the Second Temple (from Ezra to the time of Jesus), priests

pronounced a blessing at each day's sacrifice or at the end of services. This blessing is still used in Jewish and Christian liturgy as a way of seeking divine blessing (as in [6:27](#)).

Numbers 6:25

The desire for God's smile is often translated more literally *may he make his face shine upon you*. • be gracious to you: God's people need his grace and mercy in a dangerous world (cp. [Pss 31:16](#); [67:1](#); [80:3](#), [7](#), [19](#)).

Numbers 6:26

God's favor—the display of his face, or countenance—refers to his approval and special attention (cp. [Ps 30:7](#)). Divine peace (Hebrew *shalom*) is not just the absence of conflict or violence; God's peace brings complete well-being, health, and wholeness.

Numbers 6:27

The priests were the mediators of God's covenant with Israel, so their duty was to pray for God's people and invoke his blessing on them. Jesus has the same role in relation to the church (see [Rom 8:34](#); [Heb 2:17–18](#); [4:14–16](#)).

Numbers 7:1

The day Moses set up the Tabernacle was the first day of the second year after the Exodus ([Exod 40:1–2](#)). • Once Moses finished setting up the Tabernacle, he anointed and set apart (or *consecrated*) its furnishings, the altar, and its utensils (cp. [Exod 40:9–10](#); [Lev 8:10–11](#)). As the locus of sacrifice, the altar held special importance among the sacred furniture.

Numbers 7:1–89

This detailed description of offerings presented by Israel's twelve tribes at the dedication of the Tabernacle includes the dedicatory gifts brought on twelve successive days.

Numbers 7:2–9

The same tribal leaders that assisted in the registration of ch [1](#) are found in [7:2–3](#). The non-Levitical tribes supplied the Gershonites and Merarites with the wagons and oxen needed to transport the heavy structural components of the Tabernacle and other items (cp. ch [4](#)). • These vehicles and draft animals were the first offerings from the Hebrew tribes ([7:2](#)); these practical gifts were accompanied by more elaborate dedicatory offerings that were also presented by the tribal leaders ([7:10](#), [12–83](#)).

Numbers 7:9

A later Israelite attempt to transport the Ark by cart ended in tragedy ([1 Sam 6:8](#), [11](#); [2 Sam 6:3](#), [6–7](#)).

Numbers 7:10–11

In addition to the wagons and oxen, the tribal leaders also presented gifts of silver and gold vessels and other religious offerings for the altar at the time it was anointed. Beginning with the tribe of Judah, the tribal leaders brought these gifts to the Tabernacle on twelve consecutive days. The gifts came from items collected from the Egyptians when Israel departed from Egypt (cp. [Exod 12:35–36](#); [25:3](#)).

Numbers 7:12–83

One by one, the tribal leaders brought their dedicatory gifts and offerings until the entire Hebrew confederation had participated. The repetitious pattern of describing each tribal gift emphasizes the communal nature of this ceremony; all tribes played a role in consecrating their place of worship. The detailed listing might reflect the meticulous record keeping of an archive or ledger. As noted in the record for each tribe, the silver vessels contained grain offerings, and the gold vessels held incense. Every tribe also brought animals as a burnt offering, a sin offering, and a peace offering, as specified in Leviticus.

Numbers 7:84–88

The gifts and offerings of each tribe having been described, this paragraph tabulates these expensive containers, their offerings and incense, and the sacrificial animals. These large and costly gifts and sacrifices drew attention to the importance of the altar, the Tabernacle, and the God who was served there. The sacrifices were required by law; the Hebrews presented the special gifts with a generous spirit.

Numbers 7:89

Once the Tabernacle had been dedicated and set apart as holy, it was the center of divine revelation. There Moses spoke with God, God's will was disclosed, and his presence came to rest ([Lev 16:2, 13–17](#)). Such communication emanated from the Ark of the Covenant between the two cherubim above the Ark's cover, also known as the "mercy seat" (cp. [Exod 25:17–22](#)). • For the Israelites, this was the special place associated with atonement, even as the Cross has assumed that significance in Christian faith (see [Heb 9–10](#), especially [Heb 9:5](#)). God's voice, as heard by Moses the mediator, fulfilled the expectation established by [Exod 25:22](#) and [Num 30:6](#). The Lord's presence guaranteed the holiness of Israel's wilderness sanctuary.

Numbers 8:1–4

Here are specific guidelines for the placement of the elaborate lampstand (Hebrew menorah; see [Exod 25:31–40](#)) in the Tabernacle. Since the inside of the Tabernacle was dark, the illumination provided by this stylized tree of lamps aided Israel's worship.

Numbers 8:5–22

The Lord prescribed the dedication and cleansing of the Levites.

Numbers 8:7

The ceremony to make the Levites ceremonially clean consisted of sprinkling with water, shaving all hair, and donning clean clothes; this resembled the ceremonies of cleansing from ritual defilement.

• water of purification: This expression appears only here. This sprinkling symbolized the washing of sin from their lives and thus contained some of the symbolic significance of later Jewish washings and even of Christian baptism. Perhaps this water was the same as the sin-removing mixture that included ashes from the red heifer mentioned in [19:9](#) (see [Heb 9:13](#)). • The requirement to shave their entire body was also part of the process of being declared clean from the ritual impurity of defiling diseases ([Lev 14:8](#)). • The washing of clothing accompanied all instances of cleansing from ritual defilement (e.g., [Lev 15:5–27](#)).

Numbers 8:10–11

By the laying on of hands, Israel recognized the Levites' special status and offered them as their representatives before the Lord ([8:16](#)).

Numbers 8:11

The reference to Aaron's raised hands suggests that Israel offered the Levites to the Lord as a "wave offering"—the type of offering lifted up to the Lord (cp. [Lev 7:30](#)). The Levites were dedicated to duties that made them "living and holy sacrifices" (cp. [Rom 12:1](#)).

Numbers 8:12–22

The Levites had to offer appropriate sacrifices before they performed their duties in the Tabernacle ([8:15](#)).

Numbers 8:19

A plague was an appropriate punishment for unlawful actions ([11:33](#); [14:37](#)).

Numbers 8:23–26

Guidelines regarding the Levites' length of service.

• Whereas [4:3](#) states that their Tabernacle service began at age 30, [8:24](#) gives the age as 25. The discrepancy might reflect age requirements followed in different periods when the number of Levite men available for service varied, or those aged 25–29 may have been considered unofficial

workers or apprentices. • Both passages establish the retirement age at 50; retired Levites could serve the Tabernacle as guards (cp. [Ps 84:10](#)).

Numbers 9:1–14

A year after Israel's exodus from Egypt, the time came for Israel to celebrate their second Passover in the wilderness of Sinai. Those unable to celebrate it on time were given permission to do so a month later.

Numbers 9:2–3

The Hebrews were told to celebrate the Passover at the prescribed time (see [Exod 12:6](#)). • at twilight: The Hebrew day begins at sundown.

Numbers 9:4–7

When it was time to celebrate the Passover, some men were prevented by the restrictions of [Lev 7:20–21](#). Their objection arose from a desire to keep the regulation in a case where there seemed to be no good way for them to do so.

Numbers 9:8

Moses agreed to inquire of the Lord regarding this difficult case (cp. [7:89](#)).

Numbers 9:9–14

God's response to the quandary was to allow a makeup ceremony one month later for two special cases (see also [2 Chr 30](#)), but with this provision he warned that the Israelites must not neglect the Passover and must celebrate it according to the regulations.

Numbers 9:12

The bones of the Passover lamb were not to be broken (see [Exod 12:46](#); [Ps 34:20](#); [John 19:32–36](#); cp. [John 1:29](#); [1 Cor 5:7](#)). The apostle John made reference to this instruction when reporting that

Jesus' legs were not broken on the cross ([John 19:36](#)).

Numbers 9:13

If they ignored the required Passover, they must be cut off from the community. It is not clear whether this refers to the death penalty or banishment (see study note on [Lev 7:20–21](#)).

Numbers 9:14

Foreigners who lived among the Hebrews and wanted to celebrate the Passover could do so by following the same laws, but circumcision was required for males who desired to eat the Passover meal (see also [Exod 12:48–49](#)).

Numbers 9:15–23

This passage parallels [Exod 40:17, 34–38](#) and provides additional details about God's use of the pillar of cloud and fire to lead his people (see also [Exod 13:21–22](#)). The Lord faithfully and unmistakably guided his people in the wilderness.

Numbers 9:19–23

The fiery cloud, witnessed even by Israel's enemies ([14:14](#)), was a clear symbol of God's glorious presence and the means by which he directed their movement.

Numbers 10:1–10

Israel needed signals that were loud and clear so that the tribes could receive instructions. Two silver trumpets provided a simple, effective means to signal all the tribes to move. • These trumpets were not the ram's horns (Hebrew *shopar*) mentioned frequently in the Old Testament (e.g., [Josh 6:4–6](#)); they were fashioned by Israelite craftsmen from hammered silver brought out of Egypt.

Numbers 10:2-4

The two trumpets were used to get people's attention for important pronouncements (cp. [Rev 8-11](#)).

Numbers 10:5-8

When it was time to break camp, the sound of the trumpets supplemented the movement of the pillar of cloud (cp. [9:15-22](#)) by signaling when to camp and when to move on (see ch [2](#)).

Numbers 10:8

Only the priests . . . are allowed to blow the trumpets: All uses of these trumpets were related to God and his government of Israel, both of which the priests served.

Numbers 10:9-10

The trumpets marked holy events that might not readily be recognized as such. Trumpets that sounded a call to arms ([Hos 5:8](#); [Joel 2:1](#)) would remind ... the Lord to rescue the Hebrews from their enemies.

Numbers 10:11-36

Leaving Sinai was a pivotal moment in Israel's history. Now the Israelites had the law and would be tested as to how they would keep it. The departure from Sinai was the beginning of the march toward Canaan, though it turned into a long journey (cp. [Deut 1:6-8](#), [19](#)). This passage summarizes the daily procedures on the journey.

Numbers 10:12

The Israelites marched to the wilderness of Paran, an arid or semi-arid region in the northeastern part of the Sinai Peninsula, south of the Negev and west of the Dead Sea/Arabah Rift (cp. [Gen 21:21](#)).

Numbers 10:13-28

The order of march is different here than in [2:3-34](#), which specifies that all three clans of Levites were to carry the Tabernacle and its furnishings in the middle of the troop, between the groups headed by Judah and Reuben and the groups headed by Ephraim and Dan. Here, the Gershonites and Merarites carried the components of the Tabernacle structure between Judah and Reuben, and the Kohathites carried the most sacred furniture between Reuben and Ephraim. This useful arrangement allowed time for the Gershonites and Merarites to set up the Tabernacle before the Kohathites arrived with the sacred objects. It also provided security for their special cargo, and it spread the Levites out among the tribes, perhaps enhancing the leavening effect of their influence (cp. [Matt 13:33](#); [16:6](#), [11-12](#); [1 Cor 5:6-7](#)).

Numbers 10:29-32

After the trek toward Paran had begun, Moses took the practical step of asking his brother-in-law, Hobab (cp. [Judg 4:11](#)), to join the Israelites as their guide (literally *to serve as Israel's eyes*) and so to share in their promised blessings. As a Midianite shepherd, Hobab knew the routes and possible sources of food and water in this region of the Sinai Peninsula. • Reuel the Midianite: See "Jethro (Reuel)" Profile. • my own land and family: Midian was probably in northwestern Arabia. [Judges 1:16](#) suggests that Hobab accepted the appeal.

Numbers 10:33

The mountain of the Lord refers here to Mount Sinai; elsewhere the expression refers to Mount Moriah or Zion in Jerusalem ([Gen 22:14](#); [Ps 24:3](#); [Isa 2:3](#); [Zech 8:3](#)).

Numbers 10:35

Moses' invocation, spoken when the Ark set out, acknowledged the Lord as a warrior who would give Israel the Promised Land and called him to fight Israel's battles (cp. [Ps 68:1](#)).

Numbers 10:36

This invocation called the Lord to join his people and protect Israel while they camped.

Numbers 11:1

Soon the people began to complain. . . . Then the Lord's anger blazed: The link between Israel's complaints and God's anger is a major theme of Numbers and throughout the Old Testament (e.g., [Deut 9:22](#); [Ps 78](#)). God is holy and just, and he demands obedience from his people. Complaints are equivalent to rejecting him (cp. [Num 11:20](#)). • their hardship: Mount Sinai had provided a stable residence for a year; the road to Paran provided heat, thirst, and fatigue. • fire . . . destroyed some: Cp. [Lev 10:2](#).

Numbers 11:1–35

This is one of many occasions in the wilderness when Israel was disobedient to the Lord.

Numbers 11:2–3

The people sought Moses' intercession again (cp. [Exod 15:25](#); [32:11–14](#)), which brought an end to the fire of God's judgment. • Taberah: Cp. [Num 11:34–35](#); see [Deut 9:22](#).

Numbers 11:4–6

Oh, for some meat! The Israelites had flocks and herds (e.g., [32:1](#); [Exod 12:32](#), [38](#); [17:3](#); [34:3](#)), but the animals were more valuable for their dairy products and other benefits produced while alive and were only butchered for meat on a selective basis. The Hebrews would not have had enough meat to feed such a large population regularly (cp. [Num 11:21–22](#)).

Numbers 11:4–15

Israel had not relinquished the attitude that brought about the judgment at Taberah ([11:1–3](#)), so they readily joined the foreign rabble in craving the delicacies of Egypt, forgetting the misery of slavery there.

Numbers 11:6

The Lord had earlier provided manna and quail ([Exod 16](#)).

Numbers 11:7–9

The manna has often been explained as one of various edible substances that occur naturally (but see [Deut 8:3](#)); even so, its quantity and duration were miraculous.

Numbers 11:10–15

The Israelites' persistent whining led a frustrated Moses to register his own complaints with God. With biting sarcasm, Moses reminded God that he had not wanted this job in the first place (cp. [Exod 4:10](#)). Israel became such a burden that Moses wished that God would do him the favor of killing him (cp. [Job 6:9](#)). • Moses' complaint was acceptable, unlike the complaints of the people, because he was seeking the Lord rather than pining for the delights of Egypt.

Numbers 11:16–30

When Jethro proposed a judicial hierarchy ([Exod 18:13–26](#)), he was concerned with practical matters, as were the tribal leaders who helped Moses with the registration ([Num 1:5–15](#)). By contrast, this group of seventy . . . elders would provide Israel with spiritual guidance. They needed a share of God's Spirit that already rested upon Moses and made him the Lord's special spokesman. Their capacity as leaders depended on the presence of God's Spirit (cp. [1 Sam 10:6](#); [19:20](#); [Joel 2:28](#); [Acts 2:16–18](#); [1 Cor 12:10](#); [2 Pet 1:20–21](#)).

Numbers 11:25

We are not told what happened when the Spirit rested upon them and they prophesied. Whatever happened (possibly ecstatic utterances; cp. [Acts 2:4](#); [1 Cor 14:2](#)), it was a unique occurrence.

Numbers 11:28–29

Joshua's zealous protest was prompted by his jealousy in a worthy but immature desire to safeguard his master's status. Moses was humble ([Num 12:3](#)) and was not threatened by Eldad and Medad's prophecy. Instead, he was magnanimous about sharing the spotlight and happy to learn that God was working through others in such special ways. Moses had leadership qualities that the younger Joshua had not yet acquired (cp. [Mark 9:38–40](#)).

Numbers 11:31–35

God responded to the people's complaints by sending a storm of quail and a plague. God had provided quail along with manna in [Exod 16:13](#), but here they expressed God's judgment in their sickeningly overabundant supply.

Numbers 11:34–35

The precise locations of Kibroth-hattaavah and Hazeroth are unknown.

Numbers 12:1

Most interpreters understand the Cushite woman to be Moses' wife Zipporah from Midian ([Exod 2:16–22](#)), understanding *Cush* as referring here to Cushan, a region and people near Midian ([Hab 3:7](#)). Other interpreters, taking *Cushite* in its usual sense as referring to Kushi (in northern Arabia), Ethiopia, or Sudan, think that she was a different wife. In either case, it is possible that Miriam and Aaron disapproved of his having married a non-Israelite or that they were jealous of her influence over Moses.

Numbers 12:1–2

Miriam and Aaron might have perceived Moses' marriage as a threat to their status and ambitions. Miriam is named first, which suggests that she instigated this family feud and could explain why God punished her and not Aaron ([12:9–10](#)).

Numbers 12:1–16

Rebellion was not restricted to the "foreign rabble" or to the Israelites who were bored with manna ([11:4](#)). Moses' own brother and sister, Aaron the high priest ([Exod 29:30](#)) and Miriam the prophet ([Exod 15:20](#)), rebelled against him. Israel was near the nadir of its rebellion against God ([Num 13:25–14:12](#)).

Numbers 12:2

The challenge to Moses' authority was, by implication, a rejection of the Lord's choice of Moses as Israel's leader. • the Lord heard: The same phrase in [11:1](#) foreshadows the Lord's response.

Numbers 12:3

Moses' incomparable humility contrasts his godly character (see also [Prov 3:34](#); [Matt 5:5](#)) with Miriam and Aaron's jealousy. • This parenthetical comment, a simple statement of the truth from God's perspective, could be the words of Moses or of a later editor.

Numbers 12:4–8

In response, the Lord reconfirmed Moses' special status and authority.

Numbers 12:6–8

The Lord's trust in Moses resulted in an intimate relationship. God spoke to prophets in visions and dreams, but he spoke to Moses face to face (literally *mouth to mouth*; see [Exod 33:8–11](#), [18–23](#); [Deut 34:10](#)).

Numbers 12:9–16

Miriam bore the brunt of God's wrath (see study note on 12:1–2). Once Aaron saw what had happened to her, he admitted his error and sought Moses' intercession (cp. [11:2](#)). Both Moses and the Lord accepted Aaron's confession.

Numbers 12:14

Miriam was required to follow the normal procedure for achieving ritual purity after a skin disease ([5:2-4](#); [Lev 13-14](#)).

Numbers 12:16

The camp in the wilderness of Paran was at Kadesh-barnea ([13:26](#); [Deut 1:19-22](#)).

Numbers 13:1-16

Moses selected a leader from each tribe to explore the territory that God had promised to give the Hebrews. The tribes listed are those of ch [1](#), though the order is different. Caleb and Joshua are later shown to be men of faith ([14:30](#)).

Numbers 13:1-14:45

Twelve spies investigated the rich land of Canaan and found it defended by formidable foes. Israel's disobedience in earlier chapters foreshadows more of the same. The Israelites lacked the obedience, courage, and faith to take the land, so the Lord destined them to spend forty years in the Sinai wilderness; that generation failed to receive their inheritance in the Promised Land.

Numbers 13:17-20

The military purpose of the scouting mission is evident; the spies were also to gather information about natural resources and food, which had been on the Israelites' minds since they left Egypt (ch [11](#); [Exod 16](#)).

Numbers 13:20

The season for harvesting the first ripe grapes came in late July or August.

Numbers 13:21

It was about 275 miles from the wilderness of Zin, located roughly between the wilderness of Paran and the southern frontier of Canaan (see [34:3-5](#);

[Josh 15:1-4](#)), to Lebo-hamath ("entrance of Hamath," either a notable mountain pass or another city near Hamath) in Syria. • The exact location of Rehob is uncertain, but it was probably the same as Old Testament Beth-rehob, situated near a major route to Hamath. The text thus already identifies the approximate borders of the Promised Land (see [1 Kgs 8:65](#)). The phrase "from Dan to Beersheba" ([Judg 20:1](#); [2 Sam 3:10](#)), frequently used to demarcate Israel's traditional boundaries, referred to a considerably smaller area than the territory visited by Israel's spies.

Numbers 13:21-24

The spies explored the land, which was unusually fertile in contrast with the Sinai wilderness.

Numbers 13:22

Israel's spies made their way into Canaan's hill country via the Negev, the dry southland next to the wilderness of Zin. In the southern part of Canaan's central hill country, they came to Hebron, where Israel's ancestors had lived ([Gen 13:18](#); [23:19](#); [35:27](#); [37:14](#)). • The descendants of Anak were famous for their size and strength (e.g., [Deut 9:2](#)). • Zoan (later called Tanis by the Greeks) was a famous city in Egypt's eastern delta (see also [Pss 78:12, 43](#); [Isa 19:11-13](#); [30:3-5](#)).

Numbers 13:25-29

The spies agreed that the land was good, but most doubted that Israel could conquer it. The strong, well-fed Canaanites had built fortified towns to protect themselves.

Numbers 13:26

Kadesh is often identified with 'Ain el-Qudeirat, a spring at the northern border of Sinai and the southern edge of Canaan. There is no evidence of a Hebrew camp at this site during the period of the Exodus or the wilderness wanderings, so some scholars have suggested that ancient Kadesh was located elsewhere.

Numbers 13:27

The Promised Land is often described as a land flowing with milk and honey. Milk and dairy products constituted a major part of the diet in biblical times, and “milk” is used in figurative language for abundance (see [Deut 32:14](#); [Isa 55:1](#); [Joel 3:18](#)). Honey provided sweetness (see [Pss 19:10](#); [119:103](#); [Ezek 3:3](#); [Rev 10:9-10](#)). The phrase thus refers to a highly desirable destination, a land with an abundance of food and resources (cp. [Num 16:13-14](#); see also [Exod 3:8](#); [Deut 6:3](#); [26:15](#); [Jer 11:4-5](#); [Ezek 20:6](#)). The New Testament emphasizes the spiritual nature of God’s promises, pointing to a promised inheritance in heaven (see [Rom 9:6-8](#); [Gal 6:14-16](#); [Rev 21:1-2](#)).

Numbers 13:29

The spies answer the question of [13:18](#). Many ethnic groups occupied ancient Canaan.

Numbers 13:30

Caleb and Joshua (see [14:6](#), [10](#), [30](#)) were more optimistic in their assessment of the land than the other spies were (cp. [14:31-33](#)).

Numbers 13:33

giants: See study note on Gen 6:4.

Numbers 14:1-45

The testimony of the faithful spies Joshua and Caleb was rejected, and rebellion spread through the entire community. Only Moses’ intervention saved Israel from complete destruction. Those who failed to obey God died during a forty-year wilderness sojourn.

Numbers 14:3-4

The threats about which they complained were real, but the Israelites should have trusted the Lord. In the ancient Near East, women and children were often taken as plunder in the aftermath of battle. • return to Egypt: How quickly the Israelites

forgot their bondage ([Exod 2:23-24](#)) and the hardship of the wilderness ([Num 11:1](#))!

Numbers 14:5

Moses and Aaron prostrated themselves out of humility, fear, grief, and anguish.

Numbers 14:6

Joshua and Caleb joined in the effort to reverse the rebellion and avert God’s wrath; they tore their clothing in a gesture of grief.

Numbers 14:7-9

Joshua and Caleb understood that Israel’s lack of courage and their criticism of Moses and Aaron were rebellion against the Lord, and they knew what results this would produce. • the Lord is with us: This was the source of their confidence (cp. [Rom 8:31](#)).

Numbers 14:10

Joshua and Caleb, with their encouragement and expression of trust in God, brought even more opposition; the protests against the leaders were converted into threats of violence against the faithful spies. All of the Israelites’ objections came to a sudden stop when the Lord’s glorious presence (Hebrew *kabod*; see [Exod 24:15-18](#); [Ezek 1](#)) appeared at the Tabernacle, the site of divine communication.

Numbers 14:11

God marveled that Israel had not yet learned to trust him, even after he had miraculously rescued them from slavery and provided for their needs as they traveled in the wilderness (cp. [Deut 4:32-40](#); [Matt 11:21](#); [Luke 10:13](#)).

Numbers 14:12

God is patient, but he will not tolerate outright rebellion from his people (cp. [Exod 32:7-10](#)). The

writer of Hebrews refers to this episode in his effort to strengthen the faith of Christians whose trust in the Good News was wavering ([Heb 3:7-19; 12:3, 25](#); cp. [Ps 95:8-11](#)).

Numbers 14:13-25

Moses interceded on behalf of his people, reminding God that his reputation was bound up with that of Israel and appealing to his faithfulness.

Numbers 14:17-18

Moses had used this same argument earlier when he sought pardon for Israel's rebellion ([Exod 32:10-14](#)). Moses knew that God would not let the Israelites off without punishment ([Deut 7:9-10](#)).

Numbers 14:19

Israel's history since leaving Egypt had been a series of transgressions forgiven by the Lord (chs [11-12](#); [Exod 15:22-27](#); [17:1-7](#); [32:1-14](#); [Lev 10](#)).

Numbers 14:20-25

As a result of Moses' argument, the Lord pardoned Israel's rebellion and did not obliterate them, but the obstinate adult generation would never see the Promised Land.

Numbers 14:22

The people's lack of obedience and faith was a refusal to listen to God's voice, since they were eyewitnesses of the Lord's glorious presence (see study note on 14:10) and miraculous signs ([Exod 4:29-31](#); [7:1-11:10](#); [14:15-31](#); [16:1-17:13](#)).

Numbers 14:23-25

Having turned their backs on the Promised Land, the Israelites were now ordered to march the other way. • The Red Sea could refer to bodies of water on either side of the Sinai Peninsula (the Gulf of Aqaba or the Gulf of Suez).

Numbers 14:28

Israel's disobedience brought on the consequences they feared would come from obeying.

Numbers 14:34

each day: Cp. [13:25](#). • to have me for an enemy: Cp. [Ezek 5:8](#); [21:3](#).

Numbers 14:39-45

The threat of divine punishment for their sins brought grief to the people of Israel, but their hearts were still rebellious and they again disobeyed the Lord's command ([14:25](#)). The promise of God's presence had been the basis for Caleb and Joshua's initial confidence ([14:9](#)), but God would not fight alongside the Israelites until all the rebels had died.

Numbers 14:43

The Lord will abandon you because you have abandoned the Lord: Moses' prediction summarizes the whole chapter.

Numbers 14:44

The Ark symbolized God's presence and blessings (cp. [1 Sam 4:1-11](#)).

Numbers 14:45

Hormah means "destruction" in Hebrew (see [21:1-3](#)).

Numbers 15:1-3

The implication of these instructions is that the Israelites would someday settle in the Promised Land ([14:31](#); [15:18](#)).

Numbers 15:1–41

Chapters [1–14](#) took place in a relatively short period of time, but ch [15](#) describes the beginning of a long period—the bulk of the forty years in the wilderness—about which relatively little is known, though there are references to events that took place during the wilderness wanderings (e.g., [Deut 8:2–6](#); [29:5–6](#); [Josh 5:4–8](#); [Ezek 20:10–26](#); [Amos 5:25–26](#); [Acts 7:42–43](#)). During this period, Moses continued to deliver legislation to govern Israelite society, especially for that day when survivors of the wilderness would finally enter the Promised Land. This chapter deals with three categories of legal matters. Presented in the middle of stories about a stubborn and disobedient Israel, [Num 15](#) raises hope that the Promised Land still awaited Israel’s descendants.

Numbers 15:3

special gifts . . . a pleasing aroma to the Lord: God is pleased by the honor and thanksgiving that sacrifices and offerings show him.

Numbers 15:12–16

All inhabitants of the land, Israelite and foreign-born, were to be equal before the Lord in all matters (see also [Lev 24:22](#)).

Numbers 15:17–21

These gifts, signs of gratitude to God for agricultural bounty, were expected to begin after the Hebrews reached the Promised Land and had begun planting crops.

Numbers 15:22–29

Unintentional sins were treated differently than intentional sins ([15:30–31](#)), and the actions of the community were distinguished from those of an individual (see also [Lev 4–5](#)).

Numbers 15:30–31

While atonement could be made for unwitting or inadvertent sins ([15:22–29](#)), anyone who brazenly

(literally *with a high hand*; cp. [Exod 14:8](#)) violated the Lord’s will was guilty of blasphemy and suffered the consequences (cp. [Lev 24:10–16](#); see also [Deut 17:2–6](#); [Heb 10:26–31](#)). • cut off from the community: See study notes on [Exod 31:14–15](#); [Lev 7:20–21](#).

Numbers 15:32–36

This case illustrates [15:30–31](#). The Sabbath was the Lord’s holy day, which was not to be disregarded ([Exod 20:8–11](#); [31:14–15](#); [35:1–3](#)).

Numbers 15:34

Though there was no question about the man’s guilt, it is possible that the community was uncertain how to punish him. The death sentence was an appropriate penalty, because disregard of the Sabbath signaled a rejection of God’s gracious covenant with Israel ([Exod 31:12–17](#)) and was akin to blasphemy ([Num 15:30](#); [Lev 24:10–16](#); cp. [1 Tim 1:20](#)).

Numbers 15:37–41

Had the Hebrews remembered their special relationship with the Lord, they might have avoided the problems reported in Numbers. The tassels reminded Israel of their special relationship with a holy God and his demands. He had redeemed his people from Egypt, and in keeping with his call to covenant relationship with himself he expected them to observe the law (cp. [Deut 6:6–9](#); [Matt 9:20](#); [14:36](#); [23:5](#)). • The color blue signified royalty and reflected God’s holiness.

Numbers 16:1–17:13

Another rebellion called for a clear delineation of the duties of priests and Levites. This power struggle was a more serious challenge than any of the previous rebellions against God’s authority (ch [11](#); [12:1–15](#); [14:1–45](#)). As in all of these historical episodes, the coconspirators protested relatively minor issues and questioned the actions of their leaders, but Moses reminded them that they were really rebelling against God. Once again, the Israelites suffered the deadly consequences of their rebellion.

Numbers 16:3

The rebels were “jealous of Moses and envious of Aaron” ([Ps 106:16](#)). They insisted that Moses and Aaron had gone too far because all Israelites were God’s chosen people ([Exod 19:6](#)). Their egalitarian protest against Moses and Aaron’s authority was probably intended to replace that authority with their own.

Numbers 16:4–7

Moses . . . fell face down on the ground in intercession (cp. [14:5](#); [16:22](#)), then challenged Korah and his followers to a test.

Numbers 16:6

prepare your incense burners: Korah and his company were to act like priests by burning incense (as in [Lev 16:11–13](#)); God would decide who was legitimate.

Numbers 16:10

The special ministry of the Levites is described in chs [3–4](#). The priesthood was the province of Aaron’s descendants ([3:1–4](#)). The rebels’ complaint was not with Moses or Aaron, but with the Lord.

Numbers 16:13

land flowing with milk and honey: This sarcastic allusion to the spies’ earlier description of Canaan ([13:27](#)) is a deliberate distortion of life in Egypt (see study note on 11:4–15).

Numbers 16:14

The Israelites were heading away from their new homeland precisely because they had rebelled against Moses, who had done all he could to take them to that land (chs [13–14](#)). • Are you trying to fool these men? They were accusing Moses and Aaron of trying to mislead the Israelites (to “pull the wool over their eyes”).

Numbers 16:15

Do not accept their grain offerings! Cp. [Ps 109:7](#); [Prov 28:9](#).

Numbers 16:16–17

Moses gave final instructions concerning the test to see if the Lord would accept what the rebels brought or what Aaron offered.

Numbers 16:18–22

At the height of the insurrection, the Lord intervened to save Moses and Aaron, and they interceded for the people.

Numbers 16:19

The community . . . gathered at the Tabernacle entrance, either to see the test or to overthrow Moses and Aaron.

Numbers 16:21–26

The Lord threatened to destroy the entire community because of its pervasive sin (cp. [Gen 18:16–33](#)). Moses and Aaron interceded to narrow the Lord’s judgment down to those who were guilty of this particular rebellion.

Numbers 16:26

don’t touch anything that belongs to them: These men and their belongings were now “set apart for destruction” (see [Lev 27:28–29](#); cp. [Deut 7:26](#); [13:17](#); [Josh 6:18](#); [7:1–26](#)).

Numbers 16:28–30

Moses had faith that God would enact his own justice, and God did so ([16:31–35](#); cp. [1 Kgs 18:18–40](#)). • into the grave: *Sheol* was the place of the dead (see [1 Sam 2:6](#); [2 Sam 22:5–6](#); [Job 3:20–22](#); [Ps 16:10](#); [Acts 2:27–33](#); [1 Cor 15:15](#); [Rev 20:13–14](#)).

Numbers 16:31-33

Korah's sons did not die at this time ([26:10-11](#)). In fact, his descendants eventually became gatekeepers and musicians in the Temple ([1 Chr 9:19, 31; 26:19; 2 Chr 20:19](#); cp. the titles of [Pss 42; 45-49; 84-85; 87-88](#)).

Numbers 16:34-35

The 250 Israelite leaders who attempted to offer incense shared the fate of Nadab and Abihu ([Lev 10:1-2](#)) and of those who complained about the hardships of the wilderness ([Num 11:1](#); cp. [2 Kgs 1:10](#)).

Numbers 16:37

Although the men who used the incense burners were wicked, the vessels themselves were holy and had to be treated with care and respect. The burning coals were also holy and had to be scattered so that they would not be used for any other purpose.

Numbers 16:38-40

The bronze sheet made by Eleazar to cover the altar replaced or supplemented the one made previously ([Exod 38:2](#)). Like the simple blue tassels of [Num 15:37-41](#), it reminded the people of Israel of their need to obey God.

Numbers 16:41

The Israelites still exhibited the same self-destructive, defiant behavior that had caused all their troubles. Then they blamed Moses and Aaron for what happened.

Numbers 16:42-48

In reply, the Lord's glorious presence reappeared and threatened to destroy the people of Israel (cp. [16:19-20](#)). Once again, Moses and Aaron intervened by falling face down on the ground.

Numbers 16:46-50

Moses and Aaron acted quickly to rescue the Israelites from God's wrath. In an unusual procedure, Aaron carried an incense burner with burning coals among the people and thus stopped the plague.

Numbers 17:1-5

The shepherd's staff was a common possession (cp. [Ps 23:4](#)) and, like the scepter, was a symbol of authority (cp. [Jer 48:17](#)). This trial was especially appropriate because the Hebrew words translated staffs and tribes are homonyms; the Lord's choice of staff would indicate his choice of tribe.

Numbers 17:1-13

The Lord prescribed another trial to reinforce the lessons taught by the incidents in ch [16](#) and to introduce the instructions of ch [18](#).

Numbers 17:4

The staffs were in the Lord's presence ([17:7](#)), a safe spot where no one would tamper with them.

Numbers 17:8

Aaron's staff . . . produced ripe almonds! This was more than enough proof that Aaron was God's chosen leader and that the Levites held a special position. The cups on the Tabernacle's lampstand were shaped like almond blossoms ([Exod 25:33-36](#)). Later, Jeremiah's vision of an almond branch represented the Lord's vigil and his intention to carry out his plans (see [Jer 1:11-12](#)). • There is no natural explanation for the budding of Aaron's staff. Almond wood is soft while alive and only becomes hard enough for use as a staff long after it has been cut off and allowed to dry.

Numbers 17:9-11

After each tribal leader claimed his own staff, it was clear that Aaron's deserved special treatment. It

was placed permanently before the Ark to warn potential rebels and to deter Israelites who complained about the Lord and his appointed leaders. The Ark eventually contained this staff, a jar of manna, and the stone tablets of the law (cp. [Heb 9:4](#)) to remind the Israelites of their wilderness wanderings.

Numbers 17:12–13

The Lord and his Tabernacle were holy, and because of God's holiness, his sanctuary could be a dangerous place for those who were not qualified to enter it. Moses' efforts to make the people understand and respect the God of Israel were bearing fruit.

Numbers 18:1–4

The Lord gave special authority to Aaron, his sons (the priests), and his relatives (the Levites), all of whom were held responsible for offenses against the sanctuary. But the priests alone were held responsible for their own violations of God's instructions for their service.

Numbers 18:1–32

The instructions given here arose from the need demonstrated in ch [17](#) for clear boundaries between the people and the priests and Levites. The distinctive privileges of the Levites were matched by significant responsibilities. One very important aspect of their work was to safeguard the Tabernacle from unauthorized entry (ch [16](#)).

Numbers 18:3–4

all their assigned duties: See [1:47–53](#); [3:5–38](#); [4:1–33](#). • they must be careful: The Levites could go near only when the sacred objects were covered for transport.

Numbers 18:5

Aaron and the priests were the people's representatives before the Lord, so their actions had consequences for all of Israel (cp. [16:18–21](#)).

Numbers 18:5–7

Only the priests (Aaron and his descendants) could perform sacred duties inside the sanctuary proper or approach the altar, a sacred space that deserved special reverence. Only the high priest could serve in the Most Holy Place. The Levites were to serve only in the courtyard, away from the altar, except when it was time to assemble or disassemble the Tabernacle (ch [4](#)).

Numbers 18:6–7

Levites . . . your special assistants: As explained in [Num 3–4](#); see also [3:9](#); [8:16](#), [19](#).

Numbers 18:7

Any unauthorized person . . . will be put to death: This verse warned Israelites at all levels in the sacred hierarchy to avoid areas where they were not allowed. Certain sacred places were off limits to those not qualified in a technical religious sense. Access to the most sacred areas was restricted, set apart for the holiest members of the religious community. Those who broke that taboo violated God's holiness at the cost of their lives (see also [1:51](#), [53](#); [3:10](#), [29–38](#); [4:1–20](#)).

Numbers 18:8–14

The priests and Levites were to be supported by the sacrificial system (see, e.g., [Lev 7:28–36](#)). God's appointed representatives deserve compensation for their efforts (cp. [Matt 10:9–10](#); [1 Cor 9:3–10](#)).

Numbers 18:9–11

The most holy offerings were consumed only by Aaron and his sons, the priests set apart to serve in God's presence ([Exod 28:1](#); [29:44–46](#)). • This portion was a holy offering presented to God, and the priests had to respect it as such ([Num 18:10](#)). Other categories of offerings provided food for the priests and their families ([18:11–12](#)), but only if they were ceremonially clean.

Numbers 18:14

Offerings specially set apart for the Lord were available to Aaron and his extended family. The Hebrew term used here refers to the complete consecration of things or people to the Lord, either by destroying them or by giving them as an offering (see [Lev 27:28-29](#)); the second sense is intended here.

Numbers 18:15-16

The Lord provided for the Hebrew priests and their families out of what was set aside for the Lord. The priests had rights to firstborn animal offerings and to the redemption fee for Israel's firstborn sons. Both the firstborn sons and the offspring of unclean animals had to be redeemed by a fee paid in silver, since neither could be sacrificed (see [3:13](#), [40-51](#); [Exod 13:2](#)).

Numbers 18:19

These arrangements were part of an eternal and unbreakable covenant (literally *a covenant of salt*; cp. [2 Chr 13:5](#)). The covenant was apparently meant to be permanent, since salt (a preservative) was a symbol of permanence ([Lev 2:13](#)).

Numbers 18:20-21

The priests and Levites did not have a tribal homeland but were scattered among Israel's other tribes (cp. [35:1-8](#); [Deut 12:12](#); [Josh 21:1-42](#)). • I am your share and your allotment: Instead of their own territory, Israel's priests received the assurance that God himself would be their homeland, while the tribe of Levi received tithes in compensation for their sacred service.

Numbers 18:23-24

The Israelites' tithes were one tenth of the year's production of goods (see [Deut 14:22-29](#); [26:12](#); [Neh 10:35-39](#); [Mal 3:8-12](#); [Matt 23:23](#); cp. [Gen 14:17-20](#); [Heb 7:5-10](#)).

Numbers 18:25-32

Just as the Levites received a tithe of the Israelites' goods ([18:24](#)), they in turn were required to give . . . a tithe of the tithe to the priests as their own harvest offering ([18:27](#)).

Numbers 18:31

Any food received in tithes could be consumed by Levites and their families. That food was compensation (i.e., a salary) for Tabernacle service.

Numbers 18:32

The food tithes had a sacred origin as holy gifts of the people of Israel; they were not to turn these gifts into something common by neglecting to give a tithe to the priests.

Numbers 19:1-10

The water for the purification ceremony ([19:9](#)), prepared with ashes of the red heifer, may have been the same as the water of purification in [8:7](#); see also [31:19-24](#). This ceremony required the ashes of a red heifer; the color probably represented blood (cp. [Heb 9:13-14](#)).

Numbers 19:1-22

This account considers the procedure by which ordinary Israelites defiled by contact with a corpse (see [9:4-12](#); [Lev 17:15](#); [21:1-4](#), [11-12](#)) could regain ceremonial purity and keep from defiling the Tabernacle. God's holiness requires that the place where his presence dwells be kept pure and set apart from pollution (cp. [1 Cor 6:9-11](#), [18-20](#)).

Numbers 19:3-5

The need to safeguard Aaron's consecrated status (see [Lev 21:10-12](#)) required that Eleazar perform the offering of the red heifer, since it caused ritual impurity. The ceremony of the red heifer contrasted with the regular sacrifice (cp. [Lev 4:3-12](#)).

Numbers 19:6

The only other passage where a stick of cedar, a hyssop branch, and some scarlet yarn occur together is [Lev 14](#), which describes another ceremony (also “outside the camp”) that brought about ceremonial purification. Some scholars suggest that Eleazar added cedarwood and hyssop to produce an aroma. Hyssop is associated with purification ([Exod 12:22](#); [Ps 51:7](#); cp. [Heb 9:19](#)), and the scarlet yarn, like the red heifer, probably symbolized blood. Taken together, the cedarwood, hyssop, and scarlet symbolize cleansing.

Numbers 19:7–10

Three people were needed to produce and collect the heifer’s ashes—Eleazar, the man who burned the animal, and the man who gathered its ashes. All three became ritually impure for a day because of this process. This was also true for the person who used the finished product, a potion made from the ash dust and water (cp. [19:21](#)) that had the same defiling effect as blood associated with sacrifices ([Lev 6:27–28](#)).

Numbers 19:9

The purpose of the ceremony of burning the red heifer was to produce ashes. These were collected and deposited in a purified place outside the camp until the Israelites needed them in the water for the purification ceremony to remove such defilement as coming into contact with a corpse ([19:11–22](#)).

Numbers 19:11–19

Coming into contact with a human corpse produced ritual impurity for seven days (cp. [Lev 21:1–3](#)). The remedy was the water of purification, applied on the third and seventh days.

Numbers 19:13

The impurity caused by contact with a corpse was especially dangerous since a ceremonially defiled person would defile the Lord’s Tabernacle (cp. [Lev 15:31](#)). This was grounds for being cut off from the community of Israel (cp. [Num 9:13](#); [Exod 12:15](#); [Lev 7:20–21](#); [17:4–14](#); [20:17–18](#)).

Numbers 19:14–16

Death’s contagion could be transmitted to an object or to a place where death had occurred (cp. [Lev 15:1–12](#)).

Numbers 19:17–22

To cleanse with the heifer’s ashes, a special purifying mixture was made by combining ashes from the burnt purification offering with fresh water (cp. [5:17](#)).

Numbers 20:1

All in her generation shared this fate ([14:26–30](#)), including Moses and Aaron ([20:2–13](#), [22–29](#)).

Numbers 20:2

There was no water: Throughout most of the year, Sinai and the Negev are very hot and dry.

Numbers 20:2–13

In the face of yet another complaint by the people of Israel about a lack of water and food (cp. [11:4–35](#); [21:4–5](#); [Exod 15:22–25](#)), Moses and Aaron disobeyed the Lord and lost the privilege of entering the Promised Land.

Numbers 20:3

our brothers! The Israelites identified themselves with Nadab and Abihu ([Lev 10:1–5](#)), the gluttons killed by the first plague ([Num 11:33](#)), the skeptics who had already died in the wilderness ([14:29](#)), the ten unfaithful spies ([14:36–37](#)), Korah, Abiram, and Dathan, the 250 prominent men, and the 14,700 who died in the second plague ([16:32](#), [35](#), [49](#)).

Numbers 20:6

they fell face down on the ground: As in previous conflicts ([14:5](#), [10](#); [16:4](#), [19](#), [22](#)), they prostrated

themselves and awaited the glorious presence of the Lord to resolve the crisis.

Numbers 20:7-9

God heard Israel's complaints, regarded them as legitimate, and commanded Moses to solve the problem.

Numbers 20:8-9

The staff was kept before the Ark of the Covenant to prevent the Israelites from complaining (cp. [17:10](#)); it represented God's authority in the hands of Moses and Aaron. The instructions that God gives his representatives are very precise and must be followed exactly (cp. [Jas 3:1](#); see also [2 Tim 2:24-26](#)).

Numbers 20:10-12

Instead of reverently obeying God's instructions, Moses rebuked the people (Must we bring you water from this rock?) and angrily struck the rock twice with the staff ([20:11](#)). God regarded Moses' words and actions as a serious breach of faith; Moses "spoke foolishly" ([Ps 106:32-33](#); cp. [Jas 1:20](#)) and did not trust God enough to demonstrate his holiness. By not doing exactly as he was told, Moses demonstrated a lack of faith in God to provide for his people. This lack of faith is also apparent in Moses' words to the people. The Lord requires obedience and faith; anything less is an affront to his holy character ([Num 20:24](#); [27:14](#)). Such serious lack of obedience and faith had the same result as it had earlier ([14:20-23](#); see also [1 Cor 10:4-12](#)).

Numbers 20:13

Meribah: As they had at Rephidim ([Exod 17:1-7](#)), the Israelites coined a name ("Arguing") that referred more to the incident than to a geographical location. • God demonstrated his holiness through his judgment on Aaron and Moses' sin.

Numbers 20:14-21

Israel tried unsuccessfully to establish peaceful relations with Edom, with which it had apparently had no dealings since Esau (Edom) and Jacob (Israel) buried their father, Isaac ([Gen 35:29](#); [36:6-8](#); cp. [Gen 32:28](#)). Moses' appeal resembles the formal diplomatic correspondence of that era. While contacts with the Canaanites and other people groups were marked by hostility, communication with Edom was polite because of kinship ties (cp. [Deut 2:4](#); [23:7](#)). Those ties, however, were apparently not strong enough to overcome the ancient tension between Jacob and Esau ([Gen 27:41](#)).

Numbers 20:14-21.35

Here the Israelites began their trek toward the Promised Land. Moving from Kadesh, they left the Sinai Peninsula behind and entered the area east of the Jordan (Transjordan), approaching the Promised Land from the east by a less direct point of entry (see [14:25](#); cp. [Deut 2:2-6](#)).

Numbers 20:17

We won't even drink water from your wells: Edom is very dry; food and water were too scarce to provide for this substantial number of Hebrew immigrants. • We will stay on the king's road: The "King's Highway" (also [21:22](#)) is well known in the Old Testament, though its exact route is not certain. As its name indicates, this route was maintained for official purposes, including the movement of troops and trade. Along this trail, travelers could find settlements, food, and water between the Red Sea and Damascus. The route remained important into Roman and even modern times. This royal road contrasted with a much less hospitable route farther to the east called the Desert Highway.

Numbers 20:18-21

Stay out of my land: As their ancestor Esau had distrusted Jacob ([Gen 27:36](#)), the Edomites now distrusted Jacob's descendants. So Israel was forced to turn around and find another way to approach Canaan (cp. [Deut 2:4-6](#)).

Numbers 20:22–23

Israel did not follow the more direct route through the southern region east of the Jordan, the Edomite heartland ([20:21](#)). • After leaving Kadesh, the Hebrews reached Mount Hor, located on the border of the land of Edom. The precise location of Mount Hor remains unknown, though Josephus (writing in AD 70–100) linked it with the Petra region (at Jebel Haroun, “mountain of Aaron”).

Numbers 20:24–26

Aaron’s participation in the rebellion of his generation resulted in his death outside the Promised Land ([20:10–12](#)).

Numbers 20:27–29

Priestly authority was transferred when Moses placed Aaron’s priestly garments (cp. [Lev 8:7–9](#)) on Eleazar. Afterward, Aaron died at the age of 123, in the fortieth year after the Hebrews left Egypt (see [Num 33:37–39](#)). • all Israel mourned for him thirty days: This was an unusually high honor (see also [Deut 34:8](#)), since the normal period of public mourning was seven days ([Gen 50:10](#); [1 Sam 31:13](#)).

Numbers 21:1

It is possible that the Canaanite king of Arad was provoked by many enemies to the south of his territory (cp. [14:44–45](#)). • Arad and Hormah ([21:3](#)) were far to the north of Mount Hor ([20:22–29](#); [21:4](#); see study note on 20:22–23). Ancient *Arad* is usually identified with Tell Arad, located west of the modern Israeli town of Arad and about fifty miles north of Kadesh. While excavation at Tell Arad has revealed important ruins from the Early Bronze Age (about 3300–2000 BC) and the Iron Age (about 1200–500 BC), there is no evidence of occupation during Israel’s exodus and wilderness period (the Late Bronze Age, 1500–1200 BC). Some solutions link ancient Arad with another archaeological site in the region. Others claim that all such stories come from a much later period and that there is no reason to expect a correlation between excavated data and literary traditions. Another set of solutions recognizes that the evidence is fragmentary, insufficient to settle

scholarly debate or to reach a definitive conclusion. The same general kinds of problems with geographical and archaeological details are found in other parts of the Old Testament, and the solutions are often uncertain. • Atharim is otherwise unknown.

Numbers 21:1–22.1

In the march toward the Promised Land, Israel moved from Mount Hor to the plains of Moab ([22:1](#)). The account of Israel’s march is punctuated by the book’s emphasis on the Lord’s patient plan to lead Israel into Canaan despite their frailties. • Although the general direction of travel is clear, the exact route taken by the Hebrews remains unknown. Many of the places are hard to identify, and the archaeological evidence from some sites does not fit the time frame usually associated with the wilderness period. An honest appraisal of the wilderness itinerary is still beset by significant geographical and historical uncertainties.

Numbers 21:2–3

completely destroy (Hebrew *kharam*): Israel was instructed to completely destroy their enemies and their enemies’ property (see [Lev 27:28–29](#); [Deut 7:2](#); [20:17](#); [Josh 6–7](#); [10:1–11:23](#)). • This battle reflects a play on words between *kharam* and *Hormah* (Hebrew *khormah*, [Num 21:3](#)). It marks a turning point in Israel’s interaction with the Canaanites, who remained a formidable enemy throughout the period of the conquest.

Numbers 21:4–9

The “vow to the Lord” and consequent victory ([21:2–3](#)) did not eliminate Israel’s criticisms against God and Moses, even though the long journey was punishment for the same kind of complaining ([14:26–35](#)).

Numbers 21:6

This whole region provided (and still provides) habitat for extremely poisonous snakes (cp. [Isa 30:6](#)).

Numbers 21:7-9

Jesus alluded to this incident when discussing his identity and mission ([John 3:14-15](#)). • By Hezekiah's day (around 700 BC), this bronze snake had become an object of worship in Jerusalem ([2 Kgs 18:4](#)).

Numbers 21:10

The location of Oboth is uncertain.

Numbers 21:11-12

The Israelites made their way along the east side of Edom. • Iye-abarim ("ruins of Abarim" or "ruins of the region beyond") was probably near the northern bank of Zered Brook (cp. [Deut 2:13-14](#)) which separated ancient Edom from Moab ([Deut 2:8-25](#)).

Numbers 21:13

The Israelites traveled to the east of the Moabite territory that lay between the Zered Brook on the south and the Arnon River on the north. The far side of the Arnon River was probably north and east of the main east-west canyon of the Arnon; this "Grand Canyon" was an effective natural boundary line between Moab and the territory of the Amorites north of the Arnon (see [21:26](#)). • The Amorites were a group of nomadic peoples who had conquered areas from Mesopotamia to Canaan in the Middle Bronze Age (about 2000-1500 BC), including Babylon (around 1830 BC) and Assur (around 1750 BC). Amorites living in the hill country of Canaan had terrified Israel's spies ([Deut 1:26-28](#)) and had then repelled Israel's misguided attempt to enter Canaan ([Num 14:44-45](#); see [Deut 1:42-44](#)). At the time of Israel's arrival, Amorites had gained control of much of Transjordan (the area east of the Jordan); see study note on Num 21:26.

Numbers 21:14-15

The Book of the Wars of the Lord, analogous to *The Book of Jashar* ([Josh 10:13](#); [2 Sam 1:18](#)), is otherwise unknown. • Waheb (a town) and Suphah (a region) are otherwise unknown. Ar was one of

the major Moabite settlements of that day (cp. [21:28](#); [Deut 2:18](#); [Isa 15:1](#)).

Numbers 21:16-18

The location of Beer is unknown (cp. [Isa 15:8](#)). The poetic fragment describes the excavation of a new well and reflects the joy that this occasioned in a semiarid region. That the laborers were princes and leaders and the tools were scepters and staffs may indicate that digging the well included a festive ceremony.

Numbers 21:18-20

After moving north of the Arnon, the Hebrews left the wilderness on the eastern side of Moab and the recently conquered Amorite territory (see study note on 21:21-35). They turned westward toward the ridgeline that rises up from the Jordan Rift Valley, then traveled north to Pisgah Peak (see also [23:14](#); [Deut 3:17, 27](#); [34:1, 5](#)).

Numbers 21:21-22

Cp. [20:14-17](#).

Numbers 21:21-24

The territory of King Sihon was sandwiched between Moab and Ammon. The Israelites were not to invade Ammon ([Deut 2:19](#)), Edom, or Moab ([Deut 2:4-9](#)) because they were kin ([Gen 19:30-38](#); [32:3](#)), but Israel needed to cross Transjordan to enter Canaan. Sihon's territory was the natural route.

Numbers 21:21-35

The Israelite victories over King Sihon of Heshbon and King Og of Bashan were previews of the Hebrew conquest of Canaan and came to represent God's promise to assist his people in their time of need (cp. [13:10-12](#); [Deut 2:24-3:7](#); [Josh 2:10](#); [9:10](#); [12:1-6](#); [Judg 11:19-22](#); [Neh 9:22](#); [Pss 135:10-12](#); [136:17-22](#); [Jer 48:45-46](#)). • Because Israel had left the wilderness (cp. [Num 21:18, 23](#)) before arriving at Pisgah ([21:20](#)), this account is probably a

flashback of something that took place before the movement described in [21:18–20](#).

Numbers 21:25

The area conquered at this time became home to the tribes of Reuben, Gad, and Manasseh (cp. ch [32](#)).

Numbers 21:26

King Sihon of the Amorites had taken the area north of the Arnon from the Moabites, who earlier controlled it. After Israel occupied this region for several hundred years, it was reclaimed by King Mesha of Moab (see [2 Kgs 3:4–27](#)) through a campaign described in detail around 830 BC on the Mesha Inscription (also known as the Moabite Stone). • Heshbon is usually identified with Tell Hesban, which has not yielded evidence of Late Bronze Age occupation; see study note on Num 21:1.

Numbers 21:27–30

This ancient ballad was apparently an old Amorite song focusing on the exploits of King Sihon. Other interpreters assume that Israelite balladeers created it as a taunt song to ridicule Sihon's defeat and celebrate Israel's victory. The logical flow of thought from [21:26](#) to [21:27](#) would favor the former interpretation, with Israel applying the song to their own victory: Sihon and the Amorites had defeated Moab; now Israel had defeated them! Cp. [Judg 11:12–28](#).

Numbers 21:28

King Sihon had destroyed Moab's towns from his center of operations at Heshbon.

Numbers 21:29

From the ancient point of view, even Moab's supreme god Chemosh suffered defeat at the hands of the Amorite conquerors, while the people of Moab became refugees and captives.

Numbers 21:30

The area described here is the one that Israel had just conquered ([21:24](#)), making the ballad celebrating Sihon a fitting tribute to Israel's victory.

Numbers 21:33–35

Ancient Bashan was located east of the Sea of Galilee. • King Og, like Sihon, was an Amorite (see study note on 21:13). This brief account of Israel's defeat of Og is expanded in [Deut 3:1–11](#).

Numbers 21:35

Then Israel occupied their land: See ch [32](#).

Numbers 22:1

Following their victories over the Amorite kingdoms ([21:21–35](#) and study note), Israel took up residence in the plains of Moab on the eastern side of the Jordan Valley, northeast of the Dead Sea and across the river from the oasis of Jericho. The Hebrews camped there until they crossed the Jordan to enter Canaan ([Josh 3:1](#)).

Numbers 22:2–3

Balak is unknown outside of this incident ([Josh 24:9](#); [Judg 11:25](#); [Mic 6:5](#); [Rev 2:14](#)). His territory had been seized by Sihon, the Amorite king ([Num 21:26](#)), whom Israel had just defeated ([21:21–31](#)). Balak may have imagined that his tiny kingdom was next.

Numbers 22:2–24.25

The narrative of Balak and Balaam describes a pivotal moment in Israel's history and contains humor, drama, and profound theological insights. The Lord's will must be accomplished—nothing could thwart his plan for Israel.

Numbers 22:4

Midian: This desert people was descended from Abraham ([Gen 25:1–2](#); [Exod 2:15–16](#)). Their

alliance with Moab was the beginning of their conflicts with Israel ([Num 22:7](#); see [25:6](#), [14-18](#); [31:2-10](#); [Judg 6-8](#)).

Numbers 22:5-6

Balaam was a pagan religious specialist (a *diviner*) from northwest Mesopotamia (see “Balaam” Profile). Like other ancient peoples, Moab and Midian believed that the spoken word—in the form of a blessing or curse—was powerful when uttered by a skilled diviner. Members of this trained profession claimed to possess special powers to learn about and manipulate the future course of events (see [Deut 18:14](#); [1 Sam 6:2](#); [2 Kgs 21:6](#); [Isa 44:25](#); [Dan 2:1-12](#), [27-28](#); [Mic 5:12](#); [Zech 10:2](#)). Israel’s enemies appealed to Balaam to pronounce curses upon the Hebrews, for they believed that such spoken words would be effective against them. Ancient armies pronounced such curses on their enemies before they entered battle. Belief in the power of the spoken word was common in ancient Israel even when not linked with divination (e.g., [Gen 27:1-40](#); [Deut 27:15-26](#); [1 Sam 14:24-28](#); cp. [Matt 21:18-22](#)). • Pethor ([Num 22:5](#)) is probably ancient Pitru, located on the west side of the Euphrates River south of Carchemish, 400 miles from Moab.

Numbers 22:7

set out with money to pay Balaam to place a curse upon Israel: As a professional diviner, Balaam could command considerable payment for his services ([22:7](#), [17-18](#); cp. [1 Sam 9:7-8](#); [2 Kgs 8:7-9](#)).

Numbers 22:8

Stay here overnight: Balaam expected to receive a message from God at night ([22:9](#), [19-20](#); cp. [Job 4:12-16](#); [Zech 1:8](#)). • the Lord (Hebrew Yahweh): Balaam knew about Yahweh, the God of Israel, and expected a message from him as to what he could or could not do.

Numbers 22:9-18

God prohibited Balaam from going with Balak’s messengers.

Numbers 22:18

Some have read Balaam’s reply to this second delegation as his attempt to prompt a more lucrative offer, but his refusal ([24:13](#)) weighs against this view. Instead, Balaam seemed determined to obey the Lord and called him my God.

Numbers 22:19-20

Balaam agreed to inquire about the Lord’s wishes one more time. God allowed him to accompany Balak’s representatives but admonished him to do exactly what God commanded (cp. [22:35](#)).

Numbers 22:21-41

The passage is clearly making fun of this professional seer, whose spiritual insights and obedience to God are not equal to those of his donkey.

Numbers 22:22

God’s anger is puzzling in light of the permission he granted to Balaam in [22:20](#). The Lord knew that the diviner’s intentions and character were not as honorable as he claimed in conversation with Balak’s messengers. Balaam’s foolish beating of the donkey demonstrates his ungodly character ([Prov 12:10](#); cp. [1 Sam 25](#)).

Numbers 22:28-31

The only scriptural parallel to this phenomenon of a talking animal is the serpent who spoke with Eve ([Gen 3:1-5](#)). God used the donkey to rebuke the foolish diviner ([2 Pet 2:15-16](#)).

Numbers 22:34

I have sinned: Balaam admitted his mistake in not perceiving the angel of the Lord or his intention and offered to go back.

Numbers 22:35

The Lord ensured that Balaam would say only what God commanded (cp. [22:20](#)).

Numbers 22:36

It is likely that this meeting place was in the northeastern corner of Balak's small kingdom.

Numbers 22:37

Balak thought Balaam did not understand how urgent the situation was nor how great the offered payment.

Numbers 22:38

Balaam's reply reflected the lesson he had learned in the donkey incident (cp. [22:20](#), [35](#)).

Numbers 22:39–41

Balak attempted to secure Balaam's curse on Israel, first through a ritual offering and meal that would invoke the gods and Balaam, and second by taking Balaam to see the Israelite camp. • Kiriath-huzoth is an unknown location.

Numbers 22:41

Bamoth-baal ("high places of Baal") was along the ridge of hills that overlooks the plains of Moab northeast of the Dead Sea (cp. "Bamoth" in [21:19](#); [Josh 13:17](#)). It was the first of three locations to which the Moabite king took Balaam so that he could see the sprawling Israelite camp (also [Num 22:41](#); [23:14](#), [28](#)). From such a high point he could see the Israelites ([22:11](#)) and perform the ceremonies that Balak hoped would lead to a powerful imprecation (curse) against them.

Numbers 23:1

The number seven was a sacred symbol (also [23:4](#), [14](#), [29](#); cp. [Job 42:8](#); see "Symbolic Numbers" Theme Note).

Numbers 23:1–30

As a diviner, Balaam performed rituals to interpret omens and ascertain Israel's future (cp. [23:23](#); [24:1](#)). Balak had summoned him to pronounce imprecations, but God repeatedly prohibited him from doing so. • It is possible that these sacrifices were connected with the practice of *extispicy*—the examination of animal livers or other organs for an omen concerning the future. According to ancient Near Eastern texts, this form of fortune-telling was a widely practiced and highly developed art. Such practices were banned from Israel (see [Deut 18:9–14](#); cp. [Ezek 21:21](#)).

Numbers 23:7–8

Instead of cursing Israel, the seer noted their special status (cp. [Exod 19:5–6](#); [Deut 7:6–9](#)) and observed that God's blessing had turned a humble people into a great nation (cp. [Gen 12:2–3](#); [13:16](#); [28:14](#)). Balaam wished for similar good fortune to come his way ([Num 23:10](#)).

Numbers 23:7–10

In his first oracle from God ([23:5](#), [16](#)), Balaam rehearsed the circumstances that brought him to Moab, emphasized God's special relation with Israel, and declared his intention of protecting them from harm. • These poetic oracles illustrate the parallelism of Hebrew poetry. Parallel lines reinforce the content by repeating important concepts in a highly structured pattern. • Aram: Aram-naharaim ([Gen 24:10](#)) is another name for North Mesopotamia, where Balaam's home of Pethor was located ([Num 22:5](#)). • The eastern hills are a line of mountains in North Syria.

Numbers 23:13–26

Balak hoped that he would get different results if he changed the venue. The precise location of the plateau of Zophim on Pisgah Peak is unknown, though Pisgah is part of the ridgeline that overlooks the plains of Moab ([Deut 34:1](#)) in the vicinity of Bamoth-baal ([Num 22:41](#)) and Mount Peor ([23:28](#)).

Numbers 23:18–24

This oracle emphasizes God's faithfulness to his people—he would stay with them and keep all of his promises.

Numbers 23:19

Because of God's reliable character, Balaam could do nothing but bless Israel.

Numbers 23:20–21

Since the Lord would follow through on his promises to bless his people (bringing them no misfortune or trouble), Balaam was in no position to reverse God's intentions. Though God punished the Hebrews for acts of disobedience, his advocacy of Israel's cause was evident from the time he delivered them from Egypt.

Numbers 23:23–24

No curse could succeed against Israel because they had been blessed (22:12; cp. [Gen 12:2–3](#); [22:17–18](#)). Israel was safe from the harm that Moab and Midian sought to inflict through divination (cp. [Num 24:1](#)); Israel would become famous because God protected them from harm (see [Josh 2:9–11](#); cp. [Num 14:13–19](#)).

Numbers 23:27–24:14

Disappointed with Balaam's blessing, Balak hoped that yet another change of location would produce different results. Though the location of Mount Peor is unknown, this place was probably near a worship site of Baal of Peor (cp. [25:3](#), [5](#)) and the Beth-peor of [Deut 3:29](#); [34:6](#), where Moses was buried.

Numbers 24:1–2

Unlike previously ([23:3](#), [15](#)), Balaam did not resort to divination this time. He already knew that auguries and omens could not harm Israel ([23:23](#)), so he quit looking for them. Instead, Balaam was directly inspired by the Spirit of God.

Numbers 24:3–9

The third oracle contains another description of God's plan to bless Israel.

Numbers 24:5–6

God's love for his people was reflected in the blessings he showered upon them.

Numbers 24:6–7

The Lord's favor is emphasized by the comparison of Israel's situation with groves and gardens that have access to abundant water. Their growing population already reflected God's blessing ([24:7](#)), as mentioned in [23:10](#). This would also become clear in the second registration (ch [26](#)).

Numbers 24:7–9

God's blessing would enable the Israelites to overcome their enemies (see [24:15–24](#)). • Agag was an Amalekite king defeated by Saul ([1 Sam 15:7–9](#), [32–33](#)). The Amalekites, a desert people, were traditional enemies of the Hebrews (cp. [Num 14:45](#); [Exod 17:8–16](#)), and it is likely that Agag was the traditional designation for their king. Since God brought Israel out of Egypt, he fought on their behalf, like a warrior and like a wild animal (ox and lion; [Num 24:8–9](#)). • Blessed . . . cursed: See [Gen 12:3](#); [27:29](#).

Numbers 24:10

Balak clapped his hands in reproach (cp. [Job 27:23](#); [Lam 2:15](#)).

Numbers 24:14

let me tell you what the Israelites will do to your people in the future: Since Balak sought to curse Israel, he and his people would be cursed ([24:9](#)). The damage that Balak hoped to inflict on Israel would fall on Moab.

Numbers 24:15-25

This prophecy provides more specific details than the first three. Based on another vision from the Almighty ([24:16](#)), it lists some of the enemies that Israel would defeat in the future and predicts the emergence of an outstanding leader who would play a major role in these military victories ([24:17](#)).

Numbers 24:17

A star was a symbol for a king (cp. [Isa 14:12](#); [Matt 2:1-10](#)), and a scepter was an image of power and majesty (cp. [Gen 49:10](#); [Ps 45:6](#)). King David fits the description historically. The Moabites, whose defeat is mentioned in [Num 24:17](#), were among the many peoples conquered during his reign ([2 Sam 8:2](#)), though Moab remained a dangerous enemy of Israel after David's time (cp. [2 Kgs 3:1-27](#); [Isa 15-16](#); [Jer 48](#)). Many interpreters have extended the image beyond David. Christians identify Jesus of Nazareth with a star (cp. [Matt 2:2](#); [2 Pet 1:19](#); [Rev 2:28](#); [22:16](#)) and a scepter (cp. [Heb 1:8](#)). • The people of Sheth were probably the ancient Sutu, though it might refer to Edom/Seir (also conquered by David; [Num 24:18](#)), Ir (or Ar) of Moab ([24:19](#); cp. [21:28](#)), or Amalek, one of Israel's earliest and most persistent enemies ([24:20](#)).

Numbers 24:21-22

The Kenites, a desert people who occupied some of the same regions as the Amalekites and Midianites, would be destroyed by Assyria. Moses married a Kenite ([Judg 1:16](#); [4:11](#); cp. [Num 10:29-32](#)), and the Kenites remained mostly friendly with Israel thereafter (e.g., [1 Sam 15:6](#); [27:10](#); [30:27-30](#)).

Numbers 24:23

This verse, like [22:12](#), sums up the lesson of the entire incident.

Numbers 24:23-24

The oracle ends with a word about the rise and fall of invaders from Cyprus (Hebrew *Kittim*; this term probably referred to a number of Mediterranean people groups; cp. [Gen 10:4](#); [Jer 2:10](#); [Dan 11:30](#)).

Numbers 24:24

Eber, spelled the same as the ancestor of the Hebrews (cp. [Gen 10:21-25](#); [11:10-16](#)), possibly refers to a people beyond the Euphrates River, a region that fits the parallel reference to Assyria ([Josh 24:3](#); [Isa 7:20](#)).

Numbers 24:25

Balaam did not yet go back to Pethor ([31:8](#)).

Numbers 25:1

Acacia Grove: This type of tree thrives in arid regions. From here, Joshua later sent spies across the Jordan, and the Hebrews launched their conquest ([Josh 2:1](#); [3:1](#)). • Moabite women: The Moabites and Midianites shared culpability in the episode involving Balaam ([Num 22:2-4](#), [7](#); [31:8](#), [15-16](#)).

Numbers 25:1-18

Israel was camped across the Jordan from Jericho, almost on the eve of conquest, but they plunged to a new low in moral failure and spiritual bankruptcy. Balaam's advice led to the immorality and apostasy of Baal-peor ([31:16](#)); he found a way to damage Israel, if not through a curse, then through lust and idolatry. The same temptation to idolatry and immorality existed for the early church ([1 Cor 10:6, 11](#)).

Numbers 25:2

The Israelites participated in worship feasts associated with the gods of Moab (see [Ps 106:28](#)).

Numbers 25:3

Baal of Peor might refer to Chemosh ([21:29](#)) by a different name, but probably Baal ("lord"), the Canaanite god, was included on the list of deities honored by the Moabites. Numerous place-names were formed with this deity's name (e.g., Baal-gad, Baal-hermon, Baal-meon, Baal-peor), representing shrines for local manifestations of Baal. Peor was a mountain from which Balaam could see the

Israelite camp in the plains of Moab; the mountain and the related shrine of Beth-peor ([23:28](#); [25:3](#), [5](#), [18](#); [31:16](#); [Deut 3:29](#); [4:3](#), [46](#); [34:6](#); [Josh 13:20](#); [22:17](#)) were somewhere in the vicinity of Mount Nebo. • Israel's idolatry caused the Lord's anger to blaze against his people; this included a plague ([Num 25:8-9](#); [26:1](#); cp. [11:1](#), [10](#); [12:9](#)).

Numbers 25:4

As he had at Sinai ([Exod 32:27-28](#)), the Lord required swift justice. • execute . . . in broad daylight: The guilty parties were perhaps impaled and left out in the sun (see [2 Sam 21:6](#), [9](#)) so that everyone could see them and learn from their mistakes (cp. [2 Sam 12:12](#)).

Numbers 25:6

Here another Israelite defiled himself with a foreign woman; apparently both Moabite and Midianite women had been involved in the scandal ([25:1-3](#), [16-18](#); [31:1-2](#)). The man's sin was particularly brazen, as he apparently disregarded the judgment and mourning around him. • Some suggest that his tent was an unauthorized shrine associated with the worship of Yahweh, and not just Zimri's dwelling.

Numbers 25:7-9

Phinehas, acting as a representative of the priestly family, killed Zimri and Cozbi with one thrust of a spear ([25:7-8](#)), which probably indicates that they were engaged in sexual intercourse. Phinehas's zeal stopped the plague ([25:1-3](#)).

Numbers 25:10-13

Israel's identity as the Lord's people was severely threatened by their unfaithfulness on this occasion. Phinehas was as zealous as God in his pursuit of holiness and justice. As a result, Phinehas and his descendants were granted a special status; God made a special covenant of peace with Phinehas, and qualified men in his family inherited a permanent right to the priesthood (cp. [Mal 2:5](#)). This unconditional covenant was similar to that extended to David (see [Jer 33:19-22](#)).

Numbers 25:13

The deaths of Zimri and Cozbi helped to purify Israel from its sin; Phinehas's act had atoning value (see study note on [Lev 1:4](#)).

Numbers 25:16-18

Attack the Midianites and destroy them: This war is recorded in ch [31](#).

Numbers 26:1-4

As in the first registration, Moses and Eleazar (who had replaced Aaron) instructed the tribal leaders in the tabulation process.

Numbers 26:1-65

After nearly forty years, Israel again registered their men of military age (cp. chs [1-4](#)) as they camped on the plains of Moab . . . across from Jericho. The overall population had changed only slightly, with 603,550 in the first registration and 601,730 in the second. This nearly complete replacement of population ([26:63-65](#)) showed that the Lord was faithful to Israel in spite of their repeated acts of rebellion.

Numbers 26:8-11

the sons of Korah did not die that day: See study note on [16:31-33](#).

Numbers 26:33

The daughters of Zelophehad initiated important legal reform (see [27:1-11](#); [36:1-12](#)).

Numbers 26:51

In spite of warfare, plagues, and punishments, God had been faithful to Israel. The number of male warriors had shrunk by 1,820 compared to the first registration (cp. [2:32](#)), a difference of 0.3 percent.

Numbers 26:52-56

The second registration, like the first, was a military one, but it also provided the basis for distributing land to Israel's tribes in proportion to the tribes' populations (cp. [Josh 15-19](#)). • assign the land by lot: Lots were used to seek divine guidance and avoid favoritism in important matters (e.g., [Num 27:21](#); [1 Sam 10:20](#); [14:41-42](#); [Prov 18:18](#); [Acts 1:26](#)).

Numbers 26:57-61

The family of Kohath received special attention as the clan of Aaron, Moses, and Miriam.

Numbers 26:62

The Levites were numbered separately (cp. [1:47-49](#); [3:14-39](#)). • one month old or older: Cp. [3:15](#). • they were not given an allotment of land when it was divided among the Israelites: The Levites were given forty-eight towns for their use, but they received no large territory through the process described in [26:52-56](#) ([35:1-8](#); cp. [18:23-24](#)).

Numbers 26:63-65

The registration figures represent an entirely new generation of Hebrews, for everyone who came out of Egypt died in the wilderness except Caleb and Joshua. Joshua inherited Moses' position as the leader of Israel ([27:12-23](#); see "Joshua" Profile), and Caleb later played an important role as well (see "Caleb" Profile). [Numbers 26](#) documents Israel's transition from a generation under God's condemnation (ch [14](#)) to a people with a future, as predicted by Balaam's four prophecies (chs [23-24](#)).

Numbers 27:1-11

Zelophehad's lack of male heirs created an opportunity to refine the inheritance laws, which would later be refined even further (cp. [36:1-13](#)).

Numbers 27:2

The entrance of the Tabernacle was the most important public place, where significant decisions were made. The reference to this event in [Josh 17:4](#) specifically mentions Eleazar, Joshua, and the Hebrew leaders, but omits Moses' name. These women requested an exception to the law as it stood, and they brought their case to the highest tribal authorities.

Numbers 27:3-4

Zelophehad had not been part of Korah's rebellion ([16:1-50](#)); if he had been, his property rights would apparently have been voided (see [15:30](#); cp. [1 Kgs 21:7-16](#)). Israelite society was patriarchal and patrilineal, tracing ancestry and property through the male line. Zelophehad had no sons, but his daughters wanted his family property rights to continue. Zelophehad's daughters thus made a reasonable appeal for property rights equal to those of males.

Numbers 27:5-11

Moses took their case before the Lord, who accepted the women's appeal and established their case as a principle in order to preserve property within families.

Numbers 27:12

The mountains east of the river probably included Mount Nebo ([Deut 32:49](#)), from which Moses viewed the Promised Land just before his death ([Deut 34:1](#)).

Numbers 27:12-23

Israel would need leadership when they entered the land of Canaan. Joshua was commissioned to succeed Moses.

Numbers 27:15-17

Israel was on the threshold of a long battle for Canaan; Moses did not want them to flounder without a leader or lose their way like sheep

without a shepherd (cp. [1 Kgs 22:17](#); [Ezek 34:5](#); [Matt 9:36](#)).

Numbers 27:18–19

Joshua had a solid background for the role (cp. [Exod 17:8–16](#)). He had been Moses' assistant for a long time ([Num 11:28](#); cp. [Exod 33:11](#)). He was also one of the faithful spies ([Num 13–14](#)) who knew the people of Israel well. Joshua possessed the Spirit and recognized the special presence of God in his life (cp. [11:25–29](#)). His relationship with God also gave him wisdom for the tasks ahead (e.g., [Deut 34:9](#)). • lay your hands on him: This act symbolized the transfer of authority from an elder statesman to his assistant (cp. [Num 8:10–14](#)). Moses did this publicly so that Joshua's leadership would be incontestable.

Numbers 27:20–21

Joshua assumed only some of Moses' authority. Moses had face-to-face contact with God ([12:6–8](#); [Deut 34:10–12](#)), but Joshua had only indirect access to revelation, since he had to consult with Eleazar the priest on important matters ([Num 27:21](#); cp. [Exod 28:30](#); [Lev 8:8](#)). Israel would keep military and spiritual leadership separate hereafter.

Numbers 28:1–2

The Lord accepted special gifts (cp. [15:3](#)) as a pleasing aroma, a figurative expression describing God's acceptance and enjoyment of these gifts (see also [Gen 8:21](#); [Lev 1:9](#); [Eph 5:2](#); [Phil 4:18](#)). Offerings were made at appointed times according to specific instructions (see [Num 28:3–29:39](#)).

Numbers 28:1–29.40

These two chapters contain information about Israel's ritual calendar, including a list of required daily, weekly, and monthly offerings and a list of annual religious events. Thus Israel was instructed to worship God "properly and in order" ([1 Cor 14:40](#)). The annual cycle of sacrifices involved a tremendous investment of animals, grain, oil, and wine. Israel marked these special days by stopping their normal work, a kind of sacrifice that

recognized the importance of these holy days. This annual cycle included eight different occasions for worship, all of which recalled Israel's relationship with the Lord. Each worship event included a different combination of burnt, grain, liquid, and/or sin offerings. • For details on the grain and liquid offerings, see [Num 15:1–16](#). For explanations of the different types of offerings, see [Lev 1:1–7:38](#). For a description of Israel's festivals, see [Lev 23:1–44](#). For the New Testament perspective on the Old Testament sacrificial system, see [John 1:29](#); [Rom 12:1](#); [Heb 9:9–15](#); [10:1–2](#); [1 Pet 2:5](#).

Numbers 28:2

they are my food: See study notes on [Exod 29:18](#); [Deut 8:2](#).

Numbers 28:3–8

The daily offering was the foundation of the sacrificial system. Its practice was instituted at Mount Sinai (see [Exod 29:38–46](#)). • alcoholic drink: Cp. [Num 6:3](#); [Lev 10:9](#); [Deut 14:26](#).

Numbers 28:9–10

Special days called for additional offerings. The Sabbath day required a sacrifice over and above the regular burnt offering and its accompanying liquid offering. Other passages highlight the importance of the Sabbath (e.g., [Exod 20:8–11](#); [Lev 23:3](#); [Deut 5:12–15](#)).

Numbers 28:11–15

The offering of the first day of each month—the New Moon—called for the sacrifice of bulls, rams, and lambs as burnt offerings, along with a male goat as a sin offering.

Numbers 28:16–25

The Passover, followed by the Festival of Unleavened Bread, was the first of five great annual festivals; it was held in early spring (March~April). The Passover required no public sacrifices—it was a family occasion celebrated at home (see also [9:1–](#)

[4](#); [Exod 12:1–13:10](#); [Lev 23:5–8](#); [Deut 16:1–8](#)). This festival played a special role in the background of the Last Supper (see [Matt 26:17–19](#), [26–27](#); [Mark 14:12](#); [John 11:55](#); [12:1](#); [13:1](#); [18:28](#), [39](#); [19:14](#), [31](#); cp. [1 Cor 5:7](#)).

Numbers 28:26–31

The Festival of Harvest was later called the Festival of Pentecost (see [Acts 2:1](#)); see also [Lev 23:15–22](#). It celebrated the end of the barley harvest and the beginning of the wheat harvest in early summer (May~June). The Greek name *Pentecost* means “fiftieth day” (i.e., after Passover; see [Acts 20:16](#); [1 Cor 16:8](#)).

Numbers 29:1–6

the Festival of Trumpets: See also [Lev 23:23–25](#).

Numbers 29:7

Ten days later, on the tenth day of the same month: It is celebrated today as Yom Kippur (from Hebrew yom hakkippurim, [Lev 23:27](#)).

Numbers 29:7–11

The Day of Atonement was a solemn occasion, a day of fasting (see also [Lev 16](#); [23:26–32](#); [Rom 3:23–25](#); [Heb 9:7–12](#), [23–28](#)).

Numbers 29:12–38

The Feast of Tabernacles began on the fifteenth day of the seventh month. It was an eight-day harvest celebration that required many offerings ([Numbers 29:12](#), [35](#); [Exodus 34:22](#)). This festival was a joyful time for giving thanks (see [Nehemiah 8:13–18](#)). The tabernacles (or shelters) reminded the Israelites of living in tents during their time in the wilderness (see also [Leviticus 23:33–43](#); [1 Kings 8:1–2](#)).

Numbers 29:39

Public offerings were supplemented by a variety of voluntary individual gifts (cp. [Lev 23:38](#)).

Numbers 30:1–2

Vows included promises to give offerings, like Hannah's vow in [1 Samuel 1](#). It included pledges to abstain from certain things, like the Nazirite vow in [Numbers 6](#). Jesus mentioned the teachings about vows in the Sermon on the Mount in [Matthew 5:33](#).

Numbers 30:1–16

Vows were an important way to express devotion or piety, but were sometimes made in haste and were often forgotten. Voluntary pledges were commonly made on special religious occasions or in times of war. Perhaps the reference to vows and voluntary offerings ([29:39](#)) prompted the further discussion here (cp. [15:3](#); see also [6:1–21](#); [Lev 5:4–5](#); [27:1–34](#); [Deut 23:21–23](#)). These instructions were applied in the case of Hannah and Elkanah ([1 Sam 1:1–28](#)). Such practices, which included fasting, continued into the New Testament period (e.g., [Matt 6:16](#); [15:3–9](#); [Acts 18:18](#); [21:23](#)). Vows of females—young and unmarried or adult and married—were subject to approval by the responsible male who would be a financial partner in the vow. Nobody, male or female, young or old, should make a vow to God and then neglect it.

Numbers 30:3–5

A young woman was under the authority of her father, who was responsible for her actions and her financial obligations.

Numbers 30:6–8

When a young Hebrew woman married, her husband gained authority over her. He could cancel any vow or pledge she made while under her father's authority. This was only true if he canceled it as soon as he heard about it.

Numbers 30:9

A widow or a divorced woman usually returned to her father's family ([Lev 22:13](#)), but a mature single woman who made a vow or pledge was required to fulfill her religious duties.

Numbers 30:10–15

A married woman also needed the approval of her husband to make vows and pledges. Her husband could nullify her religious promise, but he had to make this decision on the day he heard about it. God did not hold the married woman guilty of breaking this promise if her husband cancelled it in the proper manner (cp. [30:5](#), [8](#), [12](#)). The self-denial mentioned in [30:13](#) probably refers to fasting. If he raised no objection, the husband's silence implied consent. He could not delay in his objection, or he would incur the guilt of a broken vow (cp. [Lev 5:4–13](#)).

Numbers 31:1–2

The Lord ordered Moses to lead Israel in a war of retaliation against the Midianites, who had joined the Moabites in leading the Hebrews into idolatry (ch [25](#)). The Midianites were a tribal people who inhabited the arid and semiarid regions south and east of Palestine and east of the Jordan River; they were counted among the “people of the east” ([Judg 6:3](#), [33](#); [7:12](#)). They lived in camps or settlements and were famous for their knowledge of desert transportation (cp. [Gen 37:28](#), [36](#); [Isa 60:6](#)). While they were descended from Abraham ([Gen 25:1–2](#)) and had been friendly toward Moses ([Exod 2:15–3:1](#); cp. [Num 10:29](#)), the elders of Midian had joined Balak in hiring Balaam to curse Israel ([22:4](#), [7](#)), whose presence threatened the peoples of Transjordan (the region east of the Jordan).

Numbers 31:3–5

Each tribe contributed 1,000 men for the battle, which enabled all of them to gain experience in combat and share in the victory.

Numbers 31:6

Phinehas son of Eleazar (the high priest) led this force of 12,000 into battle. His leadership helped to define this engagement as “holy war,” an act of revenge for the spiritual harm that Midian had inflicted on Israel (cp. [25:6–18](#); [31:15–16](#)). His zeal in this situation ([Num 25:11](#), [13](#)) was equal to what he demonstrated in the case of Zimri and Cozbi ([25:7–8](#)). • Many believe that holy objects of the sanctuary meant the Ark, which the Hebrews sometimes carried into battle (e.g., [10:35–36](#); [Josh 6:6](#); [1 Sam 4:3–11](#); cp. [Num 14:44](#)). Others suggest that they were a variety of sacred vessels associated with the Tabernacle rituals ([3:31](#); [4:15](#); [18:3](#); cp. [1 Kgs 8:4](#); [1 Chr 9:29](#); [2 Chr 5:5](#)). The Israelites probably took some or all of these holy objects as symbols of God's participation in their holy war.

Numbers 31:7

The Israelites killed all of the Midianite men in the particular groups they attacked from their camp in the plains of Moab ([31:12](#)), not all of the people who were part of the larger Midianite confederation (cp. [Judg 6–8](#)). The number of animals and virgins mentioned in [Num 31:32–35](#) indicates that the 12,000 Hebrews fought a sizable enemy force.

Numbers 31:8

Balaam son of Beor deserved to die because his counsel “caused the people of Israel to rebel against the Lord at Mount Peor” ([31:16](#)). Balaam was punished for his villainous deeds (cp. [2 Pet 2:15](#); [Jude 1:11](#)).

Numbers 31:9–13

After the battle, the Hebrews began the practice that they sometimes followed throughout the period of conquest and beyond (e.g., [Josh 6](#); [8](#); [10–11](#)). They destroyed their enemies (sometimes the total population), burned towns, and set aside spoils for their own use or as dedicated to the Lord.

Numbers 31:10

towns and villages: These were larger settlements and smaller unfortified encampments.

Numbers 31:13

outside the camp: The returning troops probably observed ceremonies to make themselves ceremonially clean. This was to avoid making the Tent of Meeting and the people unclean through contact with dead bodies ([31:19-24](#)).

Numbers 31:14-16

Moses was furious: God had commanded total destruction, but the Midianite women who had followed Balaam's advice and were largely responsible for the apostasy of Baal-peor had wrongly been given clemency.

Numbers 31:17-18

Only young virgin women were to be spared, since they had not participated in the incident at Baal-peor.

Numbers 31:19-24

Israelite warriors who had contact with corpses subjected themselves and their equipment to routine, but important, purification rituals (see [5:1-4](#); [19:1-22](#)).

Numbers 31:25-31

The plunder was divided into two equal parts, with half going to those who fought against the Midianites and half going to the Israelites who stayed behind (cp. [1 Sam 30:21-25](#)). In this sense, everyone participated in the armed conflict, but the relatively small number of warriors each received a larger portion than the much larger number of those who stayed behind.

Numbers 31:32-35

The total number of animals and young girls who were not killed was quite large, which indicates that Israel fought against many Midianites.

Numbers 31:36-47

The plunder was distributed according to the principles established in [31:25-30](#).

Numbers 31:48-49

Though it is unusual for no soldiers from an army to be killed in battle, it is not impossible. Classical authors also reported battles in which few or no Roman soldiers were killed. If the Israelites had the advantages of preparation, surprise, and overwhelming force, they could have defeated the Midianites and lost no troops, especially in light of God's blessing.

Numbers 31:50-54

The commanders gladly offered gold objects in gratitude for a great victory that resulted in no loss of life (cp. [Exod 30:12](#)). Ancient art and literature indicate that the Midianites and other desert peoples, both males and females, wore gold jewelry as adornment and as a form of portable wealth (e.g., [Judg 8:24-26](#)). Moses and Eleazar brought this large collection to the Tabernacle as a memorial of this special event (cp. [Num 16:39-40](#); [Zech 6:14](#)).

Numbers 32:1

vast numbers of livestock: The Israelites had flocks and herds when they left Egypt (cp. [Exod 12:38](#)); they acquired many more animals as loot in the war with Midian (cp. [Num 31:32-33](#)) and perhaps in their victories over Sihon and Og ([21:21-35](#)). • Gilead can refer either to the whole northern region of the plateau east of the Jordan (e.g., [32:29](#)) or only to the part of that territory between the Jabbok and the Arnon.

Numbers 32:1–5

From the time that Israel occupied the central part of the area east of the Jordan—during the military encounters described in ch [21](#)—Israel had been preparing to invade Canaan. At a moment when the Hebrews needed to safeguard their unity, two tribes asked to settle east of the Jordan River.

Numbers 32:3

Reuben, Gad, and half of Manasseh settled in the land that Israel had recently captured from Sihon the Amorite and Og of Bashan (cp. [21:21–35](#)). • Ataroth, Dibon, Jazer, Nimrah, Heshbon, and Elealeh have been linked with archaeological sites. • The location of Sibmah is unknown. • Though the location of a town called Nebo is unknown, it was certainly near a mountain or ridge of that same name, which was located along the escarpment that rises above the northern end of the Dead Sea. • The site named Beon is almost certainly the place called “Baal-meon” in [32:38](#), which probably corresponds to the ruins at Ma’in.

Numbers 32:6–15

Moses assumed that Reuben and Gad wanted to stay east of the Jordan River to avoid the dangers that awaited the other tribes in Canaan (cp. chs [13–14](#)).

Numbers 32:12

Caleb is identified as a Kenizzite, a descendant of Esau (cp. [Gen 36:10–11](#)). Apparently Caleb was not a native Israelite, but a convert who was so thoroughly integrated into the life and faith of Israel that he was called upon to represent the tribe of Judah when the twelve scouts were sent out to survey the Promised Land ([Num 13:6](#)).

Numbers 32:16–19

The Reubenites and Gadites assured Moses that they would not discourage their fellow Israelites and would support the war to its very end. There were still dangers east of the Jordan River, so they wanted to safeguard their livestock and families.

Numbers 32:20–24

Moses accepted the terms offered by Reuben and Gad. If they joined their kindred in fighting the Canaanites, they would fulfill their end of the agreement and could then return to their settlements east of the Jordan ([32:22](#)). If they failed to keep their promise, it would be a serious sin against God ([32:23](#)).

Numbers 32:25–27

Reuben and Gad did in fact fulfill the agreement ([Josh 4:12–13](#); [22:1–9](#)).

Numbers 32:28–30

Israel’s leaders—Eleazar, Joshua, and the heads of clans—would help enforce Moses’ terms (cp. [Josh 22:1–2](#)) since his death was imminent.

Numbers 32:31–32

Gad and Reuben reaffirmed their pledge before all of Israel’s leaders.

Numbers 32:33–42

The tribes of Gad and Reuben, along with half the tribe of Manasseh, settled east of the Jordan (e.g., [Deut 3:12–13](#); [4:43](#); [29:7–8](#)). These tribes occupied territory and towns taken from King Sihon the Amorite and King Og of Bashan ([Num 32:33](#); see [21:21–35](#)). • Half the tribe of Manasseh suddenly appears in the discussion of territorial distribution. Part of Manasseh settled east of the Jordan River, while another part of the tribe settled in Canaan, west of the Jordan (cp. [Josh 17:1–12](#); [22:7](#)).

Numbers 32:34–36

The precise locations of Atroth-shophan, Jogbehah, and Beth-haran are unknown. Aroer was located on the northern rim of the Arnon canyon.

Numbers 32:37–38

If names of some of the towns were changed to avoid pagan associations (e.g., “Baal,” the well-known Canaanite god, or “Nebo,” a Babylonian deity; see [Isa 46:1](#)), the alternate designations are not provided here.

Numbers 32:39–42

Three clans of Manasseh conquered part of Gilead and Bashan (cp. [Deut 3:13–15](#); [Josh 13:29–31](#)). The location of Nobah remains uncertain (cp. [Judg 8:11](#)). • Towns of Jair: Hebrew *Havvoth-jair* (cp. [Deut 3:14](#); [Josh 13:30](#); [Judg 10:4](#); [1 Kgs 4:13](#); [1 Chr 2:21–23](#)).

Numbers 33:1–2

The itinerary contains features that reflect detailed record keeping. This is the only place where Numbers says that Moses kept a record of Israel’s history (cp. [Exod 24:4](#)).

Numbers 33:1–56

This review of the entire wilderness period contains the longest integrated list of place-names in the Old Testament, from Israel’s departure from Egypt ([33:3](#); cp. [Exod 12:37](#)) until their arrival in the plains of Moab, opposite Jericho ([Num 33:49](#); cp. [22:1](#)). The forty-two way stations on this itinerary represent far more than a geographical journey; they recall Israel’s forty-year spiritual pilgrimage. In their travels between Rameses in Egypt ([33:3](#)) and Acacia-Abel-shittim on the plains of Moab ([33:49](#)), Israel finally became the people who could invade the land of Canaan and claim the promises God made to Abraham. • This itinerary does not provide enough data to plot an accurate, specific route. Most of the places cannot be identified with certainty; many of the sites appear nowhere else in the Hebrew Bible, and there are not enough clues to pinpoint their locations precisely. Furthermore, this list is partial or selective, omitting some of the place-names mentioned earlier in the journey.

Numbers 33:3

left defiantly: See [Exod 14:8](#).

Numbers 33:4

defeated the gods of Egypt: See [Exod 6:6](#); [12:12](#). This historical review draws attention to those special events that forced Pharaoh to allow the Israelite exodus from Egypt.

Numbers 33:5–15

For Israel’s wilderness itinerary between Rameses and the desert of Sinai, see [Exod 13:17–19:1](#).

Numbers 33:6

Etham: See [Exod 13:20](#).

Numbers 33:9

Elim remains impossible to identify with certainty, but it may have been the oasis (with springs and palm trees) at Wadi Gharandel.

Numbers 33:14

The entry for Rephidim (see study note on 20:13) adds a reminder of Israel’s rebellion there ([Exod 17:1–7](#)).

Numbers 33:15

Tradition associates the wilderness of Sinai with a mountainous region in the southern Sinai Peninsula near Jebel Musa (Arabic for “mountain of Moses”), though scholars have suggested other locations.

Numbers 33:16–17

Kibroth-hattaavah . . . Hazeroth: See [11:34–12:16](#).

Numbers 33:16–36

The journey between Sinai and Kadesh. Our ability to locate the named sites depends on the identification of Mount Sinai.

Numbers 33:18–30

Most of the place-names in this section appear nowhere else in the Old Testament.

Numbers 33:30–31

Moseroth was also called “Moserah” ([Deut 10:6](#)). This is where Aaron died and was buried (cp. [Num 20:22–29](#); [33:37–39](#)).

Numbers 33:35

Ezion-geber (cp. [Deut 2:8](#)) was located near the northern end of the Gulf of Aqaba.

Numbers 33:36

Israel was residing in Kadesh ([13:26](#); [27:14](#); “Kadesh-barnea,” [32:8](#)) when the spies reported on their trip through Canaan.

Numbers 33:37–49

Israel traveled from Kadesh to the plains of Moab.

Numbers 33:38–39

These details about Aaron’s death (cp. [20:22–29](#)) and his age show that he was about three years older than Moses (cp. [Deut 31:1–2](#); [34:7](#)).

Numbers 33:42–49

Good candidates for the locations of most of these sites are found east of the Jordan between the southern Arabah and the plains of Moab, opposite Jericho.

Numbers 33:47

Almon-diblathaim is probably the same place as “Beth-diblathaim” ([Jer 48:22](#)), also mentioned in the famous Mesha Inscription (see study note on [Num 21:26](#)).

Numbers 33:50–56

After the Israelites reached the plains of Moab opposite Jericho ([22:1](#)), they camped there for the rest of the period covered in Numbers (see [36:13](#)) and Deuteronomy ([Deut 34:8](#)). While they were camped there, God gave Israel specific instructions for dealing with the population of Canaan. The Lord commanded his people to destroy the people groups that occupied Canaan and to obliterate all vestiges of their religious practices (cp. [Exod 23:23–33](#); [34:11–17](#); [Deut 7:1–6](#); [12:2–4](#); [Josh 23:4–8](#)). Moses’ commands included the destruction of their carved and molten images (cp. [Lev 26:1](#)) and the demolition of their pagan shrines (see [Deut 12:2–3](#)).

Numbers 33:54

distribute the land . . . by sacred lot: See [26:53–56](#). [Chapter 34](#) describes the boundaries of the land of Canaan, which they would soon conquer and divide.

Numbers 33:55–56

Israel failed to carry out God’s instructions ([33:51–53](#)) and suffered the consequences predicted here (see [Judg 1:1–2:5](#); [2:11–3:6](#)). Israel’s enemies in the period of the judges were like splinters and thorns ([Num 33:55](#)), harassing them militarily and spiritually (cp. [2 Cor 12:7](#)).

Numbers 34:1–29

[Chapter 34](#) gives the borders of the land of Canaan, which Israel was to settle according to the guidelines in [26:52–56](#). Ever since the call of Abraham ([Gen 12:1–7](#)), the Promised Land of Canaan had stood at the heart of the Old Testament story. Though an entire generation of Hebrews died in the wilderness because they refused to believe the report of the faithful spies ([Num 13](#)),

God had reaffirmed his promise of land ([33:53](#)). Here, God reviewed the plan and identified the boundaries of the Promised Land in an idealized form (cp. [Josh 13–19](#); [Ezek 47–48](#)). Old Testament Israel did not possess the exact extent of the territory described here (though it came close in the days of David and Solomon; e.g., [2 Sam 24:1–9](#)), but these borders describe the region of Canaan as generally defined by Egyptian texts dating 1500–1200 BC (the period of the Hebrew invasion). The region actually occupied by Israel changed from time to time.

Numbers 34:3–5

Portions of the southern boundary of Canaan were familiar to Israel from earlier experiences in the wilderness of Zin on the northwestern edge of Edom (see chs [13–14](#)). This southern frontier ran east to west in an arc from the southern end of the Dead Sea to the Mediterranean Sea.

Numbers 34:4

From the southern end of the Dead Sea, the boundary ran through Scorpion Pass toward Zin (cp. [13:21](#)). The southernmost point was Kadesh-barnea (cp. [13:26](#)). Hazar-addar and Azmon are unknown.

Numbers 34:5

The Brook of Egypt (not to be confused with the Nile) designates the wadi that separates the land of Canaan from Egypt; it drains toward the Mediterranean Sea (cp. [1 Kgs 8:65](#)). In Old Testament times, Israel exercised little control over this southern coastal region.

Numbers 34:6–9

The natural western boundary of Canaan was the Mediterranean coast ([34:6](#)). The northern boundary began at the Mediterranean and ran eastward to Mount Hor somewhere in the Lebanon range (not the place of Aaron's death, [20:22–29](#)). • Lebo-hamath: Cp. [13:21](#); [1 Kgs 8:65](#); [Amos 6:14](#).

Numbers 34:11

Sea of Galilee: Its eastern edge (literally *shoulder*) is the ridge that rises rather abruptly from its eastern shoreline.

Numbers 34:12

The natural eastern border of Canaan followed the Jordan River down to the Dead Sea. As part of the Great Rift Valley, the Jordan and the Dead Sea were formidable, though not impassable, barriers. This boundary excluded the lands east of the Jordan that were occupied by Reuben, Gad, and the half-tribe of Manasseh. Those settlements were not part of Canaan per se and stood outside the Promised Land as originally defined.

Numbers 34:13–15

you are to divide . . . by sacred lot: Cp. [26:55–56](#). Because of the settlement of two and a half tribes (Reuben, Gad, and half the tribe of Manasseh) in Transjordan (cp. [32:33](#)), Canaan was to be divided among the nine and a half remaining tribes.

Numbers 34:16–29

Eleazar (the high priest) and Joshua (the political leader) were to divide the land among the remaining tribes. The ten tribal leaders who would help them are listed in [34:19–28](#).

Numbers 34:19–28

Caleb son of Jephunneh is the only tribal leader who appears elsewhere in Numbers ([13:6](#), [30](#); [14:6–38](#)). Nearly all of the older generation had already died during the wilderness period ([Num 26:63–65](#)), but the two faithful spies were still leading their people.

Numbers 35:1–34

The tribe of Levi received no territory, so ch [35](#) describes their allotment of 48 towns dispersed among the territories of Israel's other tribes (see [Josh 21](#); see also [Lev 25:32–34](#); [1 Chr 13:2](#); [2 Chr 11:14](#)). Just as the Levites had lived in the center of

the Israelite camp during the wilderness period (cp. [Num 2:17](#)), in the Promised Land they were to live among the other tribes and have a leavening influence among them (see [Deut 33:9-10](#); [2 Chr 17:7-9](#); [19:8-11](#); [35:3](#)). The cities and their surrounding pastureland were not a “homeland” (cp. [Num 18:23](#); [26:62](#)) but only a tiny fraction of the Canaanite territory dispersed among the other tribes.

Numbers 35:4-5

Readers have long attempted to explain the alleged contradiction between the 1,500 feet and the 3,000 feet. If the Hebrews conceived of a town as a fixed point, then the square of territory around each town would measure 3,000 feet on each side. Another solution is to see a distinction between pastureland ([35:4](#)) and larger pastureland ([35:5](#)) around the town. On the basis of this text, some Jewish interpreters restricted the distance that one could walk on the Sabbath to 3,000 feet (2,000 cubits) from home.

Numbers 35:6-34

Six of the Levites' towns had a special purpose as cities of refuge, places where a person who has accidentally killed someone can flee for safety. This unusual institution illustrates the humanitarian aspect of Hebrew law (see also [Deut 4:41-43](#); [19:1-13](#); [Josh 20](#)). These six Levitical towns provided a safe haven in cases of accidental or involuntary manslaughter (cp. [Exod 21:12-14](#)). Just as the forty-eight Levite towns were widely distributed across Israel's territories, the six cities of refuge were dispersed so they would be widely accessible (see [Josh 20:7-8](#)). These designated settlements supplemented the role of the altar as a temporary place of asylum (e.g., [1 Kgs 1:50-53](#); [2:28-34](#); cp. [Exod 21:14](#)). Other ancient peoples provided special places of asylum or refuge, often at the altar (see [Exod 21:12-14](#); [1 Kgs 2:28-34](#)), but only ancient Israel established whole settlements as places of sanctuary, reflecting a special interest in social justice.

Numbers 35:12

protection from a dead person's relatives who want to avenge the death: Justice was enacted

through vengeance at the hand of a designated avenger, usually a relative.

Numbers 35:15

Israelites, foreigners living among you, and traveling merchants. Anyone: The same law applied impartially to everyone; Israel had one standard of justice, not two (one for citizens, another for noncitizens), as in many societies (see also [Lev 19:15](#); [Deut 1:16-17](#); [1 Tim 5:21](#); [Jas 2:2-4](#)).

Numbers 35:15-24

The Old Testament makes a clear distinction between deliberate murder and involuntary manslaughter ([35:11](#), [22-23](#); [Exod 21:12-14](#); cp. [Num 15:22-31](#)). Murder required a penalty of execution, but an accidental death did not. The cities of refuge provided protection only for those who killed another person by accident. • The use of a weapon was proof of malicious intent.

Numbers 35:19

The avenger was the victim's closest relative; he was responsible for putting the murderer to death, carrying out the vengeance that justice required ([Gen 9:6](#)).

Numbers 35:22-23

Here are some instances in which a victim died but was not murdered through an intentional act of violence. The cities of refuge were created as places of safety for people who were responsible for such accidental deaths.

Numbers 35:24-25

If the slayer was cleared of the murder charge in his trial or hearing before the community (cp. [Deut 19:11-12](#)), he had to remain in the city of refuge to which he fled, and the avenger was not supposed to seek revenge, because the slayer was not guilty of murder. • until the death of the high priest: The priest's death probably provided a kind of expiation for the blood that had been shed; even

though the slayer was innocent of murder, human bloodshed had polluted the land ([Num 35:33](#); cp. [Gen 4:10–11](#)).

Numbers 35:26–29

The killer (*manslayer*) had to stay in a special city (called a "city of refuge") as a consequence for the death he had caused. He had to stay in a city of refuge until he or the high priest died. After the high priest's death, the *manslayer* could return home, and the *avenger of blood* could not take revenge.

Numbers 35:30

All murderers were condemned to death, but their conviction required a high standard of evidence—the testimony of two or more witnesses (cp. [Deut 17:6](#); [19:15](#)).

Numbers 35:31–32

The payment of a ransom (monetary compensation) to free a convicted murderer from execution was prohibited, since the death penalty was required (cp. [2 Sam 21:2–9](#)). Similarly, the slayer in an involuntary manslaughter could not pay a ransom to get around his confinement in a city of refuge.

Numbers 35:33

for murder pollutes the land: If the slayer in either a homicide or involuntary manslaughter were not dealt with as commanded, God regarded the land as polluted, because human bloodshed required death ([Gen 4:10–11](#); [9:6](#); contrast [Exod 21:29–30](#); see also [Lev 18:28](#); [Ezek 36:17–18](#); [Hos 4:2–3](#)). In its stern warning about the evil of murder, this entire passage highlights the absolute value of human life ([Exod 20:13](#)).

Numbers 35:34

The Lord lived among the people of Israel even as the Tabernacle stood in the middle of the Hebrew camp (see chs [1–4](#)). This meant that they must not

defile their land by ignoring God's commands or by failing to uphold justice (cp. [5:1–4](#)).

Numbers 36:1–4

Women who inherited land might marry men from another tribe; their land would then be lost by their ancestral tribe and transferred to their husband's tribe. The Year of Jubilee ([Lev 25:8–55](#)) normally provided the means for land to return to its original owner, but it pertained only to land that was sold, not to land acquired through marriage.

Numbers 36:1–13

The five daughters of Zelophehad had petitioned for, and had been granted, equitable property rights ([27:1–11](#)). Here the ramifications of that decision are discussed.

Numbers 36:5

The Lord readily provided the justice that the men of the tribe of Joseph (i.e., of the tribe of Manasseh, the son of Joseph) sought in their petition.

Numbers 36:6–9

These stipulations resolved the quandary, guaranteeing the stability and continuity of the tribal land allotments.

Numbers 36:10–12

As they had been instructed, Zelophehad's five daughters all married cousins on their father's side, keeping their father's allotment within his clan. Marriage to a first cousin was acceptable in ancient Hebrew society (cp. [Lev 18, 20](#); see also [1 Chr 23:22](#)) as well as in other Near Eastern cultures.

Numbers 36:13

Commands and regulations might refer to legal pronouncements from the whole book (cp. [Lev 27:34](#)) or only to those given on the plains of Moab ([Num 26–36](#)). • All that remained to make the

Israelites ready to enter Canaan was for Moses to remind them of their history and covenant obligations—the subjects of the book of Deuteronomy.